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Dramatis Personae

[SCENE. Athens, and the neighbouring woods]

TIMON, a noble Athenian
FLAVIUS, steward to Timon
FLAMINIUS, servant to Timon
LUCILIUS, servant to Timon
SERVILIUS, servant to Timon
APEMANTUS, a churlish philosopher
ALCIBIADES, an Athenian captain
PHRYNIA, mistress to Alcibiades
TIMANDRA, mistress to Alcibiades
LUCIUS, friend of Timon
LUCULLUS, friend of Timon
SEMPRONIUS, friend of Timon
VENTIDIUS, friend of Timon
CAPHIS, servant of Timon's creditors
SERVANT of Isidore
Two SERVANTS of Varro
TITUS, servant of Timon's creditors
HORTENSIUS, servant of Timon's creditors
LUCIUS, servant of Timon's creditors
PHILOTUS, servant of Timon's creditors

LORDS and SENATORS of Athens
Three STRANGERS, one called HOSTILIUS
An OLD ATHENIAN
POET
PAINTER
JEWELLER
MERCHANT
A FOOL
A PAGE
CUPID and Amazons in the Masque
BANDITTI
Officers, Soldiers, Servants, Thieves, Messengers and Attendants

Act I

Scene I. Athens. A hall in Timon's house

[Enter POET*,* PAINTER*,* JEWELLER *and* MERCHANT *at several doors.]*

POET

Good day, sir.

PAINTER

I am glad you're well.

POET

I have not seen you long. How goes the world?

PAINTER

It wears, sir, as it grows.

POET

Ay, that's well known.
But what particular rarity? What strange,
Which manifold record not matches? See,
Magic of bounty, all these spirits thy power
Hath conjured to attend! I know the merchant.

PAINTER

I know them both. Th' other's a jeweller.

MERCHANT

O, 'tis a worthy lord!

JEWELLER

Nay, that's most fixed.

MERCHANT

A most incomparable man, breathed, as it were,
To an untirable and continuate goodness.
He passes.

JEWELLER

I have a jewel here—

MERCHANT

O, pray let's see't. For the Lord Timon, sir?

JEWELLER

If he will touch the estimate. But for that—

POET

When we for recompense have praised the vile,
It stains the glory in that happy verse
Which aptly sings the good.

MERCHANT

[Looking at the jewel.]
'Tis a good form.

JEWELLER

And rich. Here is a water, look ye.

PAINTER

You are rapt, sir, in some work, some dedication
To the great lord.

POET

A thing slipped idly from me.
Our poesy is as a gum which oozes
From whence 'tis nourished. The fire i' th' flint
Shows not till it be struck; our gentle flame
Provokes itself and, like the current, flies
Each bound it chases. What have you there?

PAINTER

A picture, sir. When comes your book forth?

POET

Upon the heels of my presentment, sir.
Let's see your piece.

PAINTER

'Tis a good piece.

POET

So 'tis. This comes off well and excellent.

PAINTER

Indifferent.

POET

Admirable! How this grace
Speaks his own standing! What a mental power
This eye shoots forth! How big imagination
Moves in this lip! To th' dumbness of the gesture
One might interpret.

PAINTER

It is a pretty mocking of the life.
Here is a touch. Is't good?

POET

I'll say of it,
It tutors nature. Artificial strife
Lives in these touches livelier than life.

[Enter certain SENATORS*, who pass over the stage.]*

PAINTER

How this lord is followed!

POET

The senators of Athens, happy men!

PAINTER

Look, more!

POET

You see this confluence, this great flood of visitors.
I have in this rough work shaped out a man
Whom this beneath world doth embrace and hug
With amplest entertainment. My free drift
Halts not particularly, but moves itself
In a wide sea of wax. No levelled malice
Infects one comma in the course I hold,
But flies an eagle flight, bold and forth on,
Leaving no tract behind.

PAINTER

How shall I understand you?

POET

I will unbolt to you.
You see how all conditions, how all minds,
As well of glib and slipp'ry creatures as
Of grave and austere quality, tender down
Their services to Lord Timon. His large fortune,
Upon his good and gracious nature hanging,
Subdues and properties to his love and tendance
All sorts of hearts; yea, from the glass-faced flatterer
To Apemantus, that few things loves better
Than to abhor himself; even he drops down
The knee before him and returns in peace
Most rich in Timon's nod.

PAINTER

I saw them speak together.

POET

Sir, I have upon a high and pleasant hill
Feigned Fortune to be throned. The base o' th' mount
Is ranked with all deserts, all kind of natures
That labour on the bosom of this sphere
To propagate their states. Amongst them all
Whose eyes are on this sovereign lady fixed,
One do I personate of Lord Timon's frame,
Whom Fortune with her ivory hand wafts to her,
Whose present grace to present slaves and servants
Translates his rivals.

PAINTER

'Tis conceived to scope.
This throne, this Fortune, and this hill, methinks,
With one man beckoned from the rest below,

Bowing his head against the steepy mount
To climb his happiness, would be well expressed
In our condition.

POET

Nay, sir, but hear me on.
All those which were his fellows but of late,
Some better than his value, on the moment
Follow his strides, his lobbies fill with tendance,
Rain sacrificial whisperings in his ear,
Make sacred even his stirrup, and through him
Drink the free air.

PAINTER

Ay, marry, what of these?

POET

When Fortune in her shift and change of mood
Spurns down her late beloved, all his dependants,
Which laboured after him to the mountain's top
Even on their knees and hands, let him slip down,
Not one accompanying his declining foot.

PAINTER

'Tis common.
A thousand moral paintings I can show
That shall demonstrate these quick blows of Fortune's
More pregnantly than words. Yet you do well
To show Lord Timon that mean eyes have seen
The foot above the head.

[Trumpets sound. Enter LORD TIMON*, addressing himself courteously to every suitor. He is accompanied by a* MESSENGER*;* LUCILIUS *and other* SERVANTS *follow.]*

TIMON

Imprisoned is he, say you?

MESSENGER

Ay, my good lord. Five talents is his debt,
His means most short, his creditors most strait.
Your honourable letter he desires
To those have shut him up, which, failing,
Periods his comfort.

TIMON

Noble Ventidius. Well,
I am not of that feather to shake off
My friend when he must need me. I do know him
A gentleman that well deserves a help,
Which he shall have. I'll pay the debt and free him.

MESSENGER

Your lordship ever binds him.

TIMON

Commend me to him, I will send his ransom;
And, being enfranchised, bid him come to me.
'Tis not enough to help the feeble up,
But to support him after. Fare you well.

MESSENGER

All happiness to your honour.

[Exit.]

[Enter an OLD ATHENIAN.*]*

OLD ATHENIAN

Lord Timon, hear me speak.

TIMON

Freely, good father.

OLD ATHENIAN

Thou hast a servant named Lucilius.

TIMON

I have so. What of him?

OLD ATHENIAN

Most noble Timon, call the man before thee.

TIMON

Attends he here or no? Lucilius!

LUCILIUS

Here, at your lordship's service.

OLD ATHENIAN

This fellow here, Lord Timon, this thy creature,
By night frequents my house. I am a man
That from my first have been inclined to thrift,
And my estate deserves an heir more raised
Than one which holds a trencher.

TIMON

Well, what further?

OLD ATHENIAN

One only daughter have I, no kin else,
On whom I may confer what I have got.
The maid is fair, o' th' youngest for a bride,
And I have bred her at my dearest cost

In qualities of the best. This man of thine
Attempts her love. I prithee, noble lord,
Join with me to forbid him her resort;
Myself have spoke in vain.

TIMON

The man is honest.

OLD ATHENIAN

Therefore he will be, Timon.
His honesty rewards him in itself;
It must not bear my daughter.

TIMON

Does she love him?

OLD ATHENIAN

She is young and apt.
Our own precedent passions do instruct us
What levity's in youth.

TIMON

[To LUCILIUS.*]* Love you the maid?

LUCILIUS

Ay, my good lord, and she accepts of it.

OLD ATHENIAN

If in her marriage my consent be missing,
I call the gods to witness, I will choose
Mine heir from forth the beggars of the world
And dispossess her all.

TIMON

How shall she be endowed,
If she be mated with an equal husband?

OLD ATHENIAN

Three talents on the present; in future, all.

TIMON

This gentleman of mine hath served me long.
To build his fortune I will strain a little,
For 'tis a bond in men. Give him thy daughter.
What you bestow, in him I'll counterpoise,
And make him weigh with her.

OLD ATHENIAN

Most noble lord,
Pawn me to this your honour, she is his.

TIMON

My hand to thee; mine honour on my promise.

LUCILIUS

Humbly I thank your lordship. Never may
That state or fortune fall into my keeping
Which is not owed to you.

[Exeunt LUCILIUS *and* OLD ATHENIAN.*]*

POET

[Presenting his poem.]
Vouchsafe my labour, and long live your lordship.

TIMON

I thank you, you shall hear from me anon.
Go not away.—What have you there, my friend?

PAINTER

A piece of painting, which I do beseech
Your lordship to accept.

TIMON

Painting is welcome.
The painting is almost the natural man,
For since dishonour traffics with man's nature,
He is but outside; these pencilled figures are
Even such as they give out. I like your work,
And you shall find I like it. Wait attendance
Till you hear further from me.

PAINTER

The gods preserve you.

TIMON

Well fare you, gentleman. Give me your hand.
We must needs dine together. Sir, your jewel
Hath suffered under praise.

JEWELLER

What, my lord, dispraise?

TIMON

A mere satiety of commendations.
If I should pay you for 't as 'tis extolled,
It would unclew me quite.

JEWELLER

My lord, 'tis rated
As those which sell would give. But you well know
Things of like value, differing in the owners,
Are prized by their masters. Believe't, dear lord,
You mend the jewel by the wearing it.

TIMON

Well mocked.

MERCHANT

No, my good lord, he speaks the common tongue,
Which all men speak with him.

[Enter APEMANTUS.*]*

TIMON

Look who comes here. Will you be chid?

JEWELLER

We'll bear, with your lordship.

MERCHANT

He'll spare none.

TIMON

Good morrow to thee, gentle Apemantus.

APEMANTUS

Till I be gentle, stay thou for thy good morrow—
When thou art Timon's dog, and these knaves honest.

TIMON

Why dost thou call them knaves? Thou know'st them not.

APEMANTUS

Are they not Athenians?

TIMON

Yes.

APEMANTUS

Then I repent not.

JEWELLER

You know me, Apemantus?

APEMANTUS

Thou know'st I do, I called thee by thy name.

TIMON

Thou art proud, Apemantus.

APEMANTUS

Of nothing so much as that I am not like Timon.

TIMON

Whither art going?

APEMANTUS

To knock out an honest Athenian's brains.

TIMON

That's a deed thou'lt die for.

APEMANTUS

Right, if doing nothing be death by th' law.

TIMON

How lik'st thou this picture, Apemantus?

APEMANTUS

The best, for the innocence.

TIMON

Wrought he not well that painted it?

APEMANTUS

He wrought better that made the painter, and yet he's but a filthy piece of work.

PAINTER

You're a dog.

APEMANTUS

Thy mother's of my generation. What's she, if I be a dog?

TIMON

Wilt dine with me, Apemantus?

APEMANTUS

No, I eat not lords.

TIMON

An thou shouldst, thou'dst anger ladies.

APEMANTUS

O, they eat lords. So they come by great bellies.

TIMON

That's a lascivious apprehension.

APEMANTUS

So thou apprehend'st it, take it for thy labour.

TIMON

How dost thou like this jewel, Apemantus?

APEMANTUS

Not so well as plain-dealing, which will not cost a man a doit.

TIMON

What dost thou think 'tis worth?

APEMANTUS

Not worth my thinking. How now, poet?

POET

How now, philosopher?

APEMANTUS

Thou liest.

POET

Art not one?

APEMANTUS

Yes.

POET

Then I lie not.

APEMANTUS

Art not a poet?

POET

Yes.

APEMANTUS

Then thou liest. Look in thy last work, where thou hast feigned him a worthy fellow.

POET

That's not feigned, he is so.

APEMANTUS

Yes, he is worthy of thee, and to pay thee for thy labour. He that loves to be flattered is worthy o' th' flatterer. Heavens, that I were a lord!

TIMON

What wouldst do then, Apemantus?

APEMANTUS

E'en as Apemantus does now, hate a lord with my heart.

TIMON

What, thyself?

APEMANTUS

Ay.

TIMON

Wherefore?

APEMANTUS

That I had no angry wit to be a lord. Art not thou a merchant?

MERCHANT

Ay, Apemantus.

APEMANTUS

Traffic confound thee, if the gods will not.

MERCHANT

If traffic do it, the gods do it.

APEMANTUS

Traffic's thy god, and thy god confound thee!

[Trumpet sounds. Enter a MESSENGER*.]*

TIMON

What trumpet's that?

MESSENGER

'Tis Alcibiades, and some twenty horse,
All of companionship.

TIMON

Pray entertain them, give them guide to us.

[Exeunt some ATTENDANTS*.]*

You must needs dine with me. Go not you hence Till I have thanked you; when dinner's done, Show me this piece. I am joyful of your sights.

[Enter ALCIBIADES *with his company.]*

Most welcome, sir.

[They bow to each other.]

APEMANTUS

[Aside.] So, so, there!
Aches contract and starve your supple joints!
That there should be small love amongst these sweet knaves,
And all this courtesy! The strain of man's bred out
Into baboon and monkey.

ALCIBIADES

Sir, you have saved my longing, and I feed
Most hungerly on your sight.

TIMON

Right welcome, sir!
Ere we depart we'll share a bounteous time
In different pleasures. Pray you, let us in.

[Exeunt all but APEMANTUS.*]*

[Enter two LORDS.*]*

FIRST LORD

What time o' day is't, Apemantus?

APEMANTUS

Time to be honest.

FIRST LORD

That time serves still.

APEMANTUS

The more accursed thou, that still omitt'st it.

SECOND LORD

Thou art going to Lord Timon's feast?

APEMANTUS

Ay, to see meat fill knaves and wine heat fools.

SECOND LORD

Fare thee well, fare thee well.

APEMANTUS

Thou art a fool to bid me farewell twice.

SECOND LORD

Why, Apemantus?

APEMANTUS

Shouldst have kept one to thyself, for I mean to give thee none.

FIRST LORD

Hang thyself!

APEMANTUS

No, I will do nothing at thy bidding. Make thy requests to thy friend.

SECOND LORD

Away, unpeaceable dog, or I'll spurn thee hence.

APEMANTUS

I will fly, like a dog, the heels o' th' ass.

[Exit.]

FIRST LORD

He's opposite to humanity. Come, shall we in
And taste Lord Timon's bounty? He outgoes
The very heart of kindness.

SECOND LORD

He pours it out; Plutus, the god of gold,
Is but his steward. No meed but he repays
Sevenfold above itself, no gift to him
But breeds the giver a return exceeding
All use of quittance.

FIRST LORD

The noblest mind he carries
That ever governed man.

SECOND LORD

Long may he live in fortunes. Shall we in?

FIRST LORD

I'll keep you company.

[Exeunt.]

Scene II. The Same. A room of state in Timon's house

[Hautboys playing loud music. A great banquet served in, FLAVIUS *and others attending; and then enter* LORD TIMON*, the* SENATORS*, the Athenian* LORDS*,* ALCIBIADES*, and* VENTIDIUS*, which* TIMON *redeemded from prison. Then comes, dropping after all,* APEMANTUS*, discontentedly, like himself.]*

VENTIDIUS

Most honoured Timon,
It hath pleased the gods to remember my father's age
And call him to long peace.
He is gone happy and has left me rich.
Then, as in grateful virtue I am bound
To your free heart, I do return those talents,
Doubled with thanks and service, from whose help
I derived liberty.

TIMON

O, by no means,
Honest Ventidius. You mistake my love.
I gave it freely ever, and there's none
Can truly say he gives if he receives.
If our betters play at that game, we must not dare
To imitate them; faults that are rich are fair.

VENTIDIUS

A noble spirit!

TIMON

Nay, my lords, ceremony was but devised at first
To set a gloss on faint deeds, hollow welcomes,
Recanting goodness, sorry ere 'tis shown;
But where there is true friendship there needs none.
Pray, sit, more welcome are ye to my fortunes
Than my fortunes to me.

[They sit.]

FIRST LORD

My lord, we always have confessed it.

APEMANTUS

Ho, ho, confessed it? Hanged it, have you not?

TIMON

O Apemantus, you are welcome.

APEMANTUS

No,
You shall not make me welcome.
I come to have thee thrust me out of doors.

TIMON

Fie, thou'rt a churl, ye've got a humour there
Does not become a man; 'tis much to blame.
They say, my lords, *ira furor brevis est*,
But yond man is ever angry.
Go, let him have a table by himself,
For he does neither affect company,
Nor is he fit for it indeed.

APEMANTUS

Let me stay at thine apperil, Timon.
I come to observe; I give thee warning on't.

TIMON

I take no heed of thee. Thou'rt an Athenian, therefore, welcome. I myself would have no power; prithee; let my meat make thee silent.

APEMANTUS

I scorn thy meat, 'twould choke me, for I should ne'er flatter thee. O you gods, what a number of men eats Timon, and he sees 'em not! It grieves me to see so many dip their meat in one man's blood; and all the madness is, he cheers them up too.
I wonder men dare trust themselves with men.
Methinks they should invite them without knives.
Good for their meat, and safer for their lives.
There's much example for 't. The fellow that sits next him, now parts bread with him, pledges the breath of him in a divided draft, is the readiest man to kill him. 'T has been proved. If I were a huge man, I should fear to drink at meals,
Lest they should spy my wind-pipe's dangerous notes.
Great men should drink with harness on their throats.

TIMON

My lord, in heart, and let the health go round.

SECOND LORD

Let it flow this way, my good lord.

APEMANTUS

Flow this way? A brave fellow! He keeps his tides well. Those healths will make thee and thy state look ill, Timon.

Here's that which is too weak to be a sinner,
Honest water, which ne'er left man i' the mire.
This and my food are equals, there's no odds.
Feasts are too proud to give thanks to the gods.

Apemantus' grace

Immortal gods, I crave no pelf, I pray for no man but myself. Grant I may never prove so fond To trust man on his oath or bond, Or a harlot for her weeping, Or a dog that seems a-sleeping, Or a keeper with my freedom, Or my friends if I should need 'em. Amen. So fall to't. Rich men sin, and I eat root.

[He eats and drinks.]

Much good dich thy good heart, Apemantus!

TIMON

Captain Alcibiades, your heart's in the field now.

ALCIBIADES

My heart is ever at your service, my lord.

TIMON

You had rather be at a breakfast of enemies than a dinner of friends.

ALCIBIADES

So they were bleeding new, my lord, there's no meat like 'em. I could wish my best friend at such a feast.

APEMANTUS

Would all those flatterers were thine enemies then, that then thou mightst kill 'em, and bid me to 'em.

FIRST LORD

Might we but have that happiness, my lord, that you would once use our hearts, whereby we might express some part of our zeals, we should think ourselves for ever perfect.

TIMON

O, no doubt, my good friends, but the gods themselves have provided that I shall have much help from you. How had you been my

friends else? Why have you that charitable title from thousands, did not you chiefly belong to my heart? I have told more of you to myself than you can with modesty speak in your own behalf. And thus far I confirm you. O you gods, think I, what need we have any friends if we should ne'er have need of 'em? They were the most needless creatures living, should we ne'er have use for 'em, and would most resemble sweet instruments hung up in cases, that keep their sounds to themselves. Why, I have often wished myself poorer that I might come nearer to you. We are born to do benefits, and what better or properer can we call our own than the riches of our friends? O, what a precious comfort 'tis to have so many, like brothers, commanding one another's fortunes. O joy's e'en made away ere't can be born! Mine eyes cannot hold out water, methinks. To forget their faults, I drink to you.

APEMANTUS

Thou weep'st to make them drink, Timon.

SECOND LORD

Joy had the like conception in our eyes
And, at that instant like a babe sprung up.

APEMANTUS

Ho, ho! I laugh to think that babe a bastard.

THIRD LORD

I promise you, my lord, you moved me much.

APEMANTUS

Much!

[A tucket sounds.]

TIMON

What means that trump?

[Enter a SERVANT.*]*

How now?

SERVANT

Please you, my lord, there are certain ladies most desirous of admittance.

TIMON

Ladies? What are their wills?

SERVANT

There comes with them a forerunner, my lord, which bears that office, to signify their pleasures.

TIMON

I pray, let them be admitted.

[Exit SERVANT.*]*

[Enter CUPID.*]*

CUPID

Hail to thee, worthy Timon, and to all
That of his bounties taste! The five best senses
Acknowledge thee their patron and come freely
To gratulate thy plenteous bosom. There
Taste, touch, all, pleased from thy table rise;
They only now come but to feast thine eyes.

TIMON

They're welcome all, let 'em have kind admittance.
Music, make their welcome!

FIRST LORD

You see, my lord, how ample you're beloved.

[Music. Enter a masque of LADIES *as Amazons, with lutes in their hands, dancing and playing.]*

APEMANTUS

Hoy-day!
What a sweep of vanity comes this way.
They dance? They are madwomen.
Like madness is the glory of this life,
As this pomp shows to a little oil and root.
We make ourselves fools to disport ourselves,
And spend our flatteries to drink those men
Upon whose age we void it up again
With poisonous spite and envy.
Who lives that's not depraved or depraves?
Who dies that bears not one spurn to their graves
Of their friend's gift?
I should fear those that dance before me now
Would one day stamp upon me. 'T has been done.
Men shut their doors against a setting sun.

[The LORDS *rise from table, with much adoring of* TIMON*, and to show their loves each singles out an Amazon, and all dance, men with women, a lofty strain or two to the hautboys, and cease.]*

TIMON

You have done our pleasures much grace, fair ladies,
Set a fair fashion on our entertainment,
Which was not half so beautiful and kind.
You have added worth unto 't and lustre,
And entertained me with mine own device.
I am to thank you for 't.

FIRST LADY

My lord, you take us even at the best.

APEMANTUS

Faith, for the worst is filthy and would not hold taking, I doubt me.

TIMON

Ladies, there is an idle banquet attends you,
Please you to dispose yourselves.

ALL LADIES

Most thankfully, my lord.

[Exeunt CUPID *and* LADIES.*]*

TIMON

Flavius!

FLAVIUS

My lord?

TIMON

The little casket bring me hither.

FLAVIUS

Yes, my lord. *[Aside.]* More jewels yet?
There is no crossing him in 's humour;
Else I should tell him well, i' faith, I should,
When all's spent, he'd be crossed then, an he could.
'Tis pity bounty had not eyes behind,
That man might ne'er be wretched for his mind.

[Exit.]

FIRST LORD

Where be our men?

SERVANT

Here, my lord, in readiness.

SECOND LORD

Our horses!

[Enter FLAVIUS *with the casket.]*

TIMON

O, my friends, I have one word
To say to you. Look you, my good lord,
I must entreat you, honour me so much
As to advance this jewel. Accept it and wear it,
Kind my lord.

FIRST LORD

I am so far already in your gifts—

ALL

So are we all.

[Enter a SERVANT.*]*

SERVANT

My lord, there are certain nobles of the Senate
Newly alighted and come to visit you.

TIMON

They are fairly welcome.

[Exit SERVANT.*]*

FLAVIUS

I beseech your honour,
Vouchsafe me a word. It does concern you near.

TIMON

Near? Why then, another time I'll hear thee.
I prithee let's be provided to show them entertainment.

FLAVIUS

[Aside.] I scarce know how.

[Enter another SERVANT.*]*

SECOND SERVANT

May it please your honour, Lord Lucius,
Out of his free love, hath presented to you
Four milk-white horses, trapped in silver.

TIMON

I shall accept them fairly; let the presents
Be worthily entertained.

[Exit SERVANT.*]*

[Enter a THIRD SERVANT.*]*

How now? What news?

THIRD SERVANT

Please you, my lord, that honourable gentleman, Lord Lucullus, entreats your company tomorrow to hunt with him and has sent your honour two brace of greyhounds.

TIMON

I'll hunt with him; and let them be received,
Not without fair reward.

[Exit SERVANT.*]*

FLAVIUS

[Aside.] What will this come to?
He commands us to provide, and give great gifts,
And all out of an empty coffer;
Nor will he know his purse or yield me this:
To show him what a beggar his heart is,
Being of no power to make his wishes good.
His promises fly so beyond his state
That what he speaks is all in debt; he owes
For every word. He is so kind that he now
Pays interest for 't; his land's put to their books.
Well, would I were gently put out of office
Before I were forced out.
Happier is he that has no friend to feed
Than such that do e'en enemies exceed.
I bleed inwardly for my lord.

[Exit.]

TIMON

You do yourselves much wrong,
You bate too much of your own merits.
Here, my lord, a trifle of our love.

SECOND LORD

With more than common thanks I will receive it.

THIRD LORD

O, he's the very soul of bounty!

TIMON

And now I remember, my lord, you gave good words the other day of a bay courser I rode on. 'Tis yours because you liked it.

THIRD LORD

O, I beseech you, pardon me, my lord, in that.

TIMON

You may take my word, my lord. I know no man
Can justly praise but what he does affect.
I weigh my friend's affection with mine own.
I'll tell you true, I'll call to you.

ALL LORDS

O, none so welcome!

TIMON

I take all and your several visitations
So kind to heart, 'tis not enough to give;
Methinks I could deal kingdoms to my friends,
And ne'er be weary. Alcibiades,
Thou art a soldier, therefore seldom rich.
It comes in charity to thee, for all thy living
Is 'mongst the dead, and all the lands thou hast
Lie in a pitched field.

ALCIBIADES

Ay, defiled land, my lord.

FIRST LORD

We are so virtuously bound—

TIMON

And so am I to you.

SECOND LORD

So infinitely endeared—

TIMON

All to you. Lights, more lights!

FIRST LORD

The best of happiness, honour, and fortunes keep with you, Lord Timon.

TIMON

Ready for his friends.

[Exeunt all but APEMANTUS *and* TIMON.*]*

APEMANTUS

What a coil's here!
Serving of becks and jutting out of bums!
I doubt whether their legs be worth the sums
That are given for 'em. Friendship's full of dregs.
Methinks false hearts should never have sound legs.
Thus honest fools lay out their wealth on curtsies.

TIMON

Now, Apemantus, if thou wert not sullen,
I would be good to thee.

APEMANTUS

No, I'll nothing, for if I should be bribed too, there would be none left to rail upon thee, and then thou wouldst sin the faster. Thou giv'st so long, Timon, I fear me thou wilt give away thyself in paper shortly. What needs these feasts, pomps, and vainglories?

TIMON

Nay, an you begin to rail on society once, I am sworn not to give regard to you. Farewell, and come with better music.

[Exit.]

APEMANTUS

So. Thou wilt not hear me now, thou shalt not then.
I'll lock thy heaven from thee.
O, that men's ears should be
To counsel deaf, but not to flattery!

[Exit.]

Act II

Scene I. Athens. A room in a senator's house

[Enter a SENATOR *with papers.]*

SENATOR

And late five thousand. To Varro and to Isidore
He owes nine thousand, besides my former sum,
Which makes it five-and-twenty. Still in motion
Of raging waste! It cannot hold; it will not.
If I want gold, steal but a beggar's dog
And give it Timon, why, the dog coins gold.
If I would sell my horse, and buy twenty more
Better than he, why, give my horse to Timon—
Ask nothing, give it him—it foals me straight,
And able horses. No porter at his gate,
But rather one that smiles and still invites
All that pass by. It cannot hold; no reason
Can sound his state in safety. Caphis, ho!
Caphis, I say!

[Enter CAPHIS.*]*

CAPHIS

Here, sir, what is your pleasure?

SENATOR

Get on your cloak and haste you to Lord Timon.
Importune him for my moneys; be not ceased
With slight denial, nor then silenced when
"Commend me to your master", and the cap
Plays in the right hand, thus; but tell him,
My uses cry to me, I must serve my turn
Out of mine own, his days and times are past,
And my reliances on his fracted dates
Have smit my credit. I love and honour him,
But must not break my back to heal his finger.
Immediate are my needs, and my relief
Must not be tossed and turned to me in words,
But find supply immediate. Get you gone.
Put on a most importunate aspect,
A visage of demand, for I do fear
When every feather sticks in his own wing,
Lord Timon will be left a naked gull,
Which flashes now a phoenix. Get you gone.

CAPHIS

I go, sir.

SENATOR

Take the bonds along with you,
And have the dates in. Come.

CAPHIS

I will, sir.

SENATOR

Go.

[Exeunt.]

Scene II. The same. A hall in Timon's house

[Enter FLAVIUS *with many bills in his hand.]*

FLAVIUS

No care, no stop, so senseless of expense,
That he will neither know how to maintain it
Nor cease his flow of riot. Takes no account
How things go from him, nor resumes no care
Of what is to continue. Never mind
Was to be so unwise, to be so kind.
What shall be done? He will not hear till feel.
I must be round with him, now he comes from hunting.
Fie, fie, fie, fie!

[Enter CAPHIS *and the* SERVANTS *of* ISIDORE *and* VARRO.*]*

CAPHIS

Good even, Varro. What, you come for money?

VARRO'S SERVANT

Is't not your business too?

CAPHIS

It is. And yours too, Isidore?

ISIDORE'S SERVANT

It is so.

CAPHIS

Would we were all discharged!

VARRO'S SERVANT

I fear it.

CAPHIS

Here comes the lord.

[Enter TIMON *and his train with* ALCIBIADES*]*

TIMON

So soon as dinner's done, we'll forth again,
My Alcibiades. With me? What is your will?

CAPHIS

My lord, here is a note of certain dues.

TIMON

Dues? Whence are you?

CAPHIS

Of Athens here, my lord.

TIMON

Go to my steward.

CAPHIS

Please it your lordship, he hath put me off
To the succession of new days this month.
My master is awaked by great occasion
To call upon his own and humbly prays you
That with your other noble parts you'll suit
In giving him his right.

TIMON

Mine honest friend,
I prithee but repair to me next morning.

CAPHIS

Nay, good my lord—

TIMON

Contain thyself, good friend.

VARRO'S SERVANT

One Varro's servant, my good lord—

ISIDORE'S SERVANT

From Isidore. He humbly prays your speedy payment.

CAPHIS

If you did know, my lord, my master's wants—

VARRO'S SERVANT

'Twas due on forfeiture, my lord, six weeks and past.

ISIDORE'S SERVANT

Your steward puts me off, my lord, and I
Am sent expressly to your lordship.

TIMON

Give me breath.
I do beseech you, good my lords, keep on,
I'll wait upon you instantly.

[Exeunt ALCIBIADES *and* TIMON*'s train.]*

[To FLAVIUS.*]* Come hither. Pray you, How goes the world, that I am thus encountered With clamorous demands of debt, broken bonds, And the detention of long-since-due debts Against my honour?

FLAVIUS

Please you, gentlemen,
The time is unagreeable to this business.
Your importunacy cease till after dinner,
That I may make his lordship understand
Wherefore you are not paid.

TIMON

Do so, my friends.
See them well entertained.

[Exit.]

FLAVIUS

Pray, draw near.

[Exit.]

[Enter APEMANTUS *and* FOOL*.]*

CAPHIS

Stay, stay, here comes the fool with Apemantus.
Let's ha' some sport with 'em.

VARRO'S SERVANT

Hang him, he'll abuse us.

ISIDORE'S SERVANT

A plague upon him, dog!

VARRO'S SERVANT

How dost, fool?

APEMANTUS

Dost dialogue with thy shadow?

VARRO'S SERVANT

I speak not to thee.

APEMANTUS

No, 'tis to thyself.
[To the FOOL.*]* Come away.

ISIDORE'S SERVANT

[To VARRO'S SERVANT.*]* There's the fool hangs on your back already.

APEMANTUS

No, thou stand'st single; thou'rt not on him yet.

CAPHIS

Where's the fool now?

APEMANTUS

He last asked the question. Poor rogues and usurers' men, bawds between gold and want.

ALL SERVANTS

What are we, Apemantus?

APEMANTUS

Asses.

ALL SERVANTS

Why?

APEMANTUS

That you ask me what you are, and do not know yourselves. Speak to 'em, fool.

FOOL

How do you, gentlemen?

ALL SERVANTS

Gramercies, good fool. How does your mistress?

FOOL

She's e'en setting on water to scald such chickens as you are. Would we could see you at Corinth!

APEMANTUS

Good, gramercy.

[Enter PAGE.*]*

FOOL

Look you, here comes my mistress' page.

PAGE

[To the FOOL.*]* Why, how now, captain? What do you in this wise company? How dost thou, Apemantus?

APEMANTUS

Would I had a rod in my mouth, that I might answer thee profitably.

PAGE

Prithee, Apemantus, read me the superscription of these letters. I know not which is which.

APEMANTUS

Canst not read?

PAGE

No.

APEMANTUS

There will little learning die, then, that day thou art hanged. This is to Lord Timon, this to Alcibiades. Go, thou wast born a bastard, and thou'lt die a bawd.

PAGE

Thou wast whelped a dog, and thou shalt famish a dog's death. Answer not; I am gone.

[Exit PAGE.*]*

APEMANTUS

E'en so thou outrunn'st grace. Fool, I will go with you to Lord Timon's.

FOOL

Will you leave me there?

APEMANTUS

If Timon stay at home.—You three serve three usurers?

ALL SERVANTS

Ay, would they served us!

APEMANTUS

So would I—as good a trick as ever hangman served thief.

FOOL

Are you three usurers' men?

ALL SERVANTS

Ay, fool.

FOOL

I think no usurer but has a fool to his servant. My mistress is one, and I am her fool. When men come to borrow of your masters, they approach sadly and go away merry, but they enter my mistress's house merrily and go away sadly. The reason of this?

VARRO'S SERVANT

I could render one.

APEMANTUS

Do it then, that we may account thee a whoremaster and a knave, which notwithstanding, thou shalt be no less esteemed.

VARRO'S SERVANT

What is a whoremaster, fool?

FOOL

A fool in good clothes, and something like thee. 'Tis a spirit; sometime 't appears like a lord, sometime like a lawyer, sometime like a philosopher, with two stones more than's artificial one. He is very often like a knight; and generally, in all shapes that man goes up and down in from fourscore to thirteen, this spirit walks in.

VARRO'S SERVANT

Thou art not altogether a fool.

FOOL

Nor thou altogether a wise man. As much foolery as I have, so much wit thou lack'st.

APEMANTUS

That answer might have become Apemantus.

VARRO'S SERVANT

Aside, aside, here comes Lord Timon.

[Enter TIMON *and* FLAVIUS.*]*

APEMANTUS

Come with me, fool, come.

FOOL

I do not always follow lover, elder brother, and woman; sometime the philosopher.

[Exeunt APEMANTUS *and* FOOL.*]*

FLAVIUS

Pray you walk near. I'll speak with you anon.

[Exeunt SERVANTS.*]*

TIMON

You make me marvel wherefore ere this time
Had you not fully laid my state before me,
That I might so have rated my expense
As I had leave of means.

FLAVIUS

You would not hear me,
At many leisures I proposed.

TIMON

Go to.
Perchance some single vantages you took
When my indisposition put you back,
And that unaptness made your minister
Thus to excuse yourself.

FLAVIUS

O my good lord,
At many times I brought in my accounts,
Laid them before you; you would throw them off
And say you found them in mine honesty.
When for some trifling present you have bid me
Return so much, I have shook my head and wept,
Yea, 'gainst th' authority of manners, prayed you
To hold your hand more close. I did endure
Not seldom nor no slight checks, when I have
Prompted you in the ebb of your estate
And your great flow of debts. My loved lord,

Though you hear now, too late, yet now's a time.
The greatest of your having lacks a half
To pay your present debts.

TIMON

Let all my land be sold.

FLAVIUS

'Tis all engaged, some forfeited and gone,
And what remains will hardly stop the mouth
Of present dues; the future comes apace.
What shall defend the interim? And at length
How goes our reckoning?

TIMON

To Lacedaemon did my land extend.

FLAVIUS

O my good lord, the world is but a word;
Were it all yours to give it in a breath,
How quickly were it gone!

TIMON

You tell me true.

FLAVIUS

If you suspect my husbandry or falsehood,
Call me before th' exactest auditors
And set me on the proof. So the gods bless me,
When all our offices have been oppressed
With riotous feeders, when our vaults have wept
With drunken spilth of wine, when every room
Hath blazed with lights and brayed with minstrelsy,
I have retired me to a wasteful cock
And set mine eyes at flow.

TIMON

Prithee, no more.

FLAVIUS

Heavens, have I said, the bounty of this lord!
How many prodigal bits have slaves and peasants
This night englutted? Who is not Timon's?
What heart, head, sword, force, means, but is Lord Timon's?
Great Timon, noble, worthy, royal Timon!
Ah, when the means are gone that buy this praise,
The breath is gone whereof this praise is made.
Feast-won, fast-lost; one cloud of winter showers,
These flies are couched.

TIMON

Come, sermon me no further.
No villainous bounty yet hath passed my heart;
Unwisely, not ignobly, have I given.
Why dost thou weep? Canst thou the conscience lack
To think I shall lack friends? Secure thy heart.
If I would broach the vessels of my love
And try the argument of hearts by borrowing,
Men and men's fortunes could I frankly use
As I can bid thee speak.

FLAVIUS

Assurance bless your thoughts!

TIMON

And in some sort these wants of mine are crowned,
That I account them blessings. For by these
Shall I try friends. You shall perceive how you
Mistake my fortunes. I am wealthy in my friends.
Within there! Flaminius! Servilius!

[Enter FLAMINIUS*,* SERVILIUS *and a* THIRD SERVANT*.]*

SERVANTS

My lord, my lord.

TIMON

I will dispatch you severally. *[To* SERVILIUS*.]* You to Lord Lucius; *[To* FLAMINIUS*.]* to Lord Lucullus you, I hunted with his honour today; *[To the* THIRD SERVANT*.]* you to Sempronius. Commend me to their loves; and I am proud, say, that my occasions have found time to use 'em toward a supply of money. Let the request be fifty talents.

FLAMINIUS

As you have said, my lord.

[Exeunt SERVANTS*.]*

FLAVIUS

[Aside.] Lord Lucius and Lucullus? Humh!

TIMON

Go you, sir, to the senators,
Of whom, even to the state's best health, I have
Deserved this hearing, Bid 'em send o' th' instant
A thousand talents to me.

FLAVIUS

I have been bold—
For that I knew it the most general way—
To them to use your signet and your name,
But they do shake their heads, and I am here
No richer in return.

TIMON

Is't true? Can't be?

FLAVIUS

They answer in a joint and corporate voice
That now they are at fall, want treasure, cannot
Do what they would, are sorry. You are honourable,
But yet they could have wished—they know not—
Something hath been amiss—a noble nature
May catch a wrench—would all were well—'tis pity.
And so, intending other serious matters,
After distasteful looks and these hard fractions,
With certain half-caps and cold-moving nods
They froze me into silence.

TIMON

You gods, reward them!
Prithee, man, look cheerly. These old fellows
Have their ingratitude in them hereditary.
Their blood is caked, 'tis cold, it seldom flows;
'Tis lack of kindly warmth they are not kind;
And nature, as it grows again toward earth,
Is fashioned for the journey, dull and heavy.
Go to Ventidius. Prithee, be not sad,
Thou art true and honest, ingenuously I speak,
No blame belongs to thee. Ventidius lately
Buried his father, by whose death he's stepped
Into a great estate. When he was poor,
Imprisoned and in scarcity of friends,
I cleared him with five talents. Greet him from me,
Bid him suppose some good necessity
Touches his friend, which craves to be remembered
With those five talents. That had, give't these fellows
To whom 'tis instant due. Ne'er speak, or think
That Timon's fortunes 'mong his friends can sink.

[Exit.]

FLAVIUS

I would I could not think it.
That thought is bounty's foe;
Being free itself, it thinks all others so.

[Exit.]

Act III

Scene I. Athens. A room in Lucullus' house

*[*FLAMINIUS *waiting to speak with* LUCULLUS *from his master.]*

[Enter a SERVANT *to him.]*

SERVANT

I have told my lord of you; he is coming down to you.

FLAMINIUS

I thank you, sir.

[Enter LUCULLUS.*]*

SERVANT

Here's my lord.

LUCULLUS

[Aside.] One of Lord Timon's men? A gift, I warrant. Why, this hits right. I dreamt of a silver basin and ewer tonight.—Flaminius, honest Flaminius, you are very respectively welcome, sir. Fill me some wine.

[Exit SERVANT.*]*

And how does that honourable, complete, free-hearted gentleman of Athens, thy very bountiful good lord and master?

FLAMINIUS

His health is well, sir.

LUCULLUS

I am right glad that his health is well, sir. And what hast thou there under thy cloak, pretty Flaminius?

FLAMINIUS

Faith, nothing but an empty box, sir, which in my lord's behalf I come to entreat your honour to supply; who, having great and instant occasion to use fifty talents, hath sent to your lordship to furnish him, nothing doubting your present assistance therein.

LUCULLUS

La, la, la, la! Nothing doubting, says he? Alas, good lord! A noble gentleman 'tis, if he would not keep so good a house. Many a time and often I ha' dined with him, and told him on't, and come again to supper to him of purpose to have him spend less, and yet he would embrace no counsel, take no warning by my coming. Every man has his fault, and honesty is his. I ha' told him on't, but I could ne'er get him from 't.

[Enter SERVANT *with wine.]*

SERVANT

Please your lordship, here is the wine.

LUCULLUS

Flaminius, I have noted thee always wise. Here's to thee.

FLAMINIUS

Your lordship speaks your pleasure.

LUCULLUS

I have observed thee always for a towardly prompt spirit, give thee thy due, and one that knows what belongs to reason, and canst use the time well, if the time use thee well. Good parts in thee. *[To* SERVANT.*]* Get you gone, sirrah.—

[Exit SERVANT.*]*

Draw nearer, honest Flaminius. Thy lord's a bountiful gentleman, but thou art wise and thou know'st well enough, although thou com'st to me, that this is no time to lend money, especially upon bare friendship without security. Here's three solidares for thee. Good boy, wink at me, and say thou saw'st me not. Fare thee well.

FLAMINIUS

Is't possible the world should so much differ,
And we alive that lived? Fly, damned baseness,
To him that worships thee.

[Throws the money back.]

LUCULLUS

Ha! Now I see thou art a fool and fit for thy master.

[Exit.]

FLAMINIUS

May these add to the number that may scald thee!
Let molten coin be thy damnation,
Thou disease of a friend, and not himself!
Has friendship such a faint and milky heart
It turns in less than two nights? O you gods,
I feel my master's passion. This slave
Unto his honour has my lord's meat in him.
Why should it thrive and turn to nutriment
When he is turned to poison?
O, may diseases only work upon't,
And when he's sick to death, let not that part of nature
Which my lord paid for be of any power
To expel sickness, but prolong his hour.

[Exit.]

Scene II. A public place

[Enter LUCIUS *with three* STRANGERS.*]*

LUCIUS

Who, the Lord Timon? He is my very good friend and an honourable gentleman.

FIRST STRANGER

We know him for no less, though we are but strangers to him. But I can tell you one thing, my lord, and which I hear from common rumours: now Lord Timon's happy hours are done and past, and his estate shrinks from him.

LUCIUS

Fie, no, do not believe it; he cannot want for money.

SECOND STRANGER

But believe you this, my lord, that, not long ago one of his men was with the Lord Lucullus to borrow so many talents, nay, urged extremely for't, and showed what necessity belonged to't, and yet was denied.

LUCIUS

How?

SECOND STRANGER

I tell you, denied, my lord.

LUCIUS

What a strange case was that! Now, before the gods, I am ashamed on't. Denied that honourable man? There was very little honour showed in't. For my own part, I must needs confess, I have received some small kindnesses from him, as money, plate, jewels, and such like trifles, nothing comparing to his; yet had he mistook him, and sent to me, I should ne'er have denied his occasion so many talents.

[Enter SERVILIUS.*]*

SERVILIUS

See, by good hap, yonder's my lord; I have sweat to see his honour. *[To* LUCIUS.*]* My honoured lord!

LUCIUS

Servilius? You are kindly met, sir. Fare thee well. Commend me to thy honourable virtuous lord, my very exquisite friend.

SERVILIUS

May it please your honour, my lord hath sent—

LUCIUS

Ha! What has he sent? I am so much endeared to that lord; he's ever sending. How shall I thank him, thinkest thou? And what has he sent now?

SERVILIUS

Has only sent his present occasion now, my lord, requesting your lordship to supply his instant use with so many talents.

LUCIUS

I know his lordship is but merry with me;
He cannot want fifty-five hundred talents.

SERVILIUS

But in the meantime he wants less, my lord.
If his occasion were not virtuous,
I should not urge it half so faithfully.

LUCIUS

Dost thou speak seriously, Servilius?

SERVILIUS

Upon my soul, 'tis true, sir.

LUCIUS

What a wicked beast was I to disfurnish myself against such a good time, when I might ha' shown myself honourable! How unluckily it happened that I should purchase the day before for a little part, and undo a great deal of honour! Servilius, now before the gods, I am not able to do—the more beast, I say—I was sending to use Lord Timon myself, these gentlemen can witness; but I would not for the wealth of Athens I had done it now. Commend me bountifully to his good lordship, and I hope his honour will conceive the fairest of me, because I have no power to be kind. And tell him this from me: I count it one of my greatest afflictions, say, that I cannot pleasure such an honourable gentleman. Good Servilius, will you befriend me so far as to use mine own words to him?

SERVILIUS

Yes, sir, I shall.

LUCIUS

I'll look you out a good turn, Servilius.

[Exit SERVILIUS.*]*

True, as you said, Timon is shrunk indeed, And he that's once denied will hardly speed.

[Exit.]

FIRST STRANGER

Do you observe this, Hostilius?

SECOND STRANGER

Ay, too well.

FIRST STRANGER

Why, this is the world's soul, and just of the same piece
Is every flatterer's spirit. Who can call him his friend
That dips in the same dish? For, in my knowing,
Timon has been this lord's father
And kept his credit with his purse,

Supported his estate, nay, Timon's money
Has paid his men their wages. He ne'er drinks
But Timon's silver treads upon his lip,
And yet—O, see the monstrousness of man
When he looks out in an ungrateful shape—
He does deny him, in respect of his,
What charitable men afford to beggars.

THIRD STRANGER

Religion groans at it.

FIRST STRANGER

For mine own part,
I never tasted Timon in my life,
Nor came any of his bounties over me
To mark me for his friend. Yet I protest,
For his right noble mind, illustrious virtue,
And honourable carriage,
Had his necessity made use of me,
I would have put my wealth into donation,
And the best half should have returned to him,
So much I love his heart. But I perceive
Men must learn now with pity to dispense,
For policy sits above conscience.

[Exeunt.]

Scene III. The same. A room in Sempronius' house

[Enter a THIRD SERVANT *of* TIMON*'s with* SEMPRONIUS*, another of* TIMON*'s* FRIENDS*.]*

SEMPRONIUS

Must he needs trouble me in't? Hum! 'Bove all others?
He might have tried Lord Lucius or Lucullus;
And now Ventidius is wealthy too,
Whom he redeemed from prison. All these
Owe their estates unto him.

SERVANT

My lord,
They have all been touched and found base metal,
For they have all denied him.

SEMPRONIUS

How? Have they denied him?
Has Ventidius and Lucullus denied him
And does he send to me? Three? Humh!
It shows but little love or judgment in him.
Must I be his last refuge? His friends, like physicians,
Thrive, give him over. Must I take th' cure upon me?
Has much disgraced me in't. I'm angry at him,
That might have known my place. I see no sense for't
But his occasions might have wooed me first;
For, in my conscience, I was the first man
That e'er received gift from him.
And does he think so backwardly of me now
That I'll requite it last? No.
So it may prove an argument of laughter
To th' rest, and I 'mongst lords be thought a fool.
I'd rather than the worth of thrice the sum
Had sent to me first, but for my mind's sake;
I'd such a courage to do him good. But now return,
And with their faint reply this answer join:
Who bates mine honour shall not know my coin.

[Exit.]

SERVANT

Excellent! Your lordship's a goodly villain. The devil knew not what he did when he made man politic; he crossed himself by't, and I cannot think but, in the end the villainies of man will set him clear. How fairly this lord strives to appear foul! Takes virtuous copies to be wicked, like those that under hot ardent zeal would set whole realms on fire.

Of such a nature is his politic love.
This was my lord's best hope, now all are fled
Save only the gods. Now his friends are dead,
Doors that were ne'er acquainted with their wards
Many a bounteous year must be employed
Now to guard sure their master.
And this is all a liberal course allows,
Who cannot keep his wealth must keep his house.

[Exit.]

Scene IV. A hall in Timon's house

[Enter two of VARRO*'s* SERVANTS *meeting* TITUS *and* HORTENSIUS *and then* LUCIUS*,* ALL SERVANTS *of* TIMON*'s creditors, to wait for his coming out.]*

FIRST VARRO'S SERVANT

Well met, good morrow, Titus and Hortensius.

TITUS

The like to you, kind Varro.

HORTENSIUS

Lucius!
What, do we meet together?

LUCIUS

Ay, and I think
One business does command us all;
For mine is money.

TITUS

So is theirs and ours.

[Enter PHILOTUS.*]*

LUCIUS

And, sir, Philotus too!

PHILOTUS

Good day at once.

LUCIUS

Welcome, good brother.
What do you think the hour?

PHILOTUS

Labouring for nine.

LUCIUS

So much?

PHILOTUS

Is not my lord seen yet?

LUCIUS

Not yet.

PHILOTUS

I wonder on't, he was wont to shine at seven.

LUCIUS

Ay, but the days are waxed shorter with him.
You must consider that a prodigal course
Is like the sun's, but not like his recoverable.
I fear 'tis deepest winter in Lord Timon's purse:
That is, one may reach deep enough, and yet
Find little.

PHILOTUS

I am of your fear for that.

TITUS

I'll show you how t' observe a strange event.
Your lord sends now for money?

HORTENSIUS

Most true, he does.

TITUS

And he wears jewels now of Timon's gift,
For which I wait for money.

HORTENSIUS

It is against my heart.

LUCIUS

Mark how strange it shows,
Timon in this should pay more than he owes,
And e'en as if your lord should wear rich jewels
And send for money for 'em.

HORTENSIUS

I'm weary of this charge, the gods can witness.
I know my lord hath spent of Timon's wealth,
And now ingratitude makes it worse than stealth.

FIRST VARRO'S SERVANT

Yes, mine's three thousand crowns. What's yours?

LUCIUS

Five thousand mine.

FIRST VARRO'S SERVANT

'Tis much deep, and it should seem by th' sum
Your master's confidence was above mine,
Else surely his had equalled.

[Enter FLAMINIUS.*]*

TITUS

One of Lord Timon's men.

LUCIUS

Flaminius? Sir, a word. Pray, is my lord ready to come forth?

FLAMINIUS

No, indeed he is not.

TITUS

We attend his lordship; pray, signify so much.

FLAMINIUS

I need not tell him that, he knows you are too diligent.

[Exit FLAMINIUS.*]*

[Enter FLAVIUS *in a cloak, muffled.]*

LUCIUS

Ha, is not that his steward muffled so?
He goes away in a cloud. Call him, call him.

TITUS

Do you hear, sir?

SECOND VARRO'S SERVANT

By your leave, sir.

FLAVIUS

What do you ask of me, my friend?

TITUS

We wait for certain money here, sir.

FLAVIUS

Ay,
If money were as certain as your waiting,
'Twere sure enough.
Why then preferred you not your sums and bills
When your false masters eat of my lord's meat?
Then they could smile and fawn upon his debts,
And take down th' interest into their gluttonous maws.
You do yourselves but wrong to stir me up,
Let me pass quietly.
Believe't, my lord and I have made an end,
I have no more to reckon, he to spend.

LUCIUS

Ay, but this answer will not serve.

FLAVIUS

If 'twill not serve, 'tis not so base as you,
For you serve knaves.

[Exit.]

FIRST VARRO'S SERVANT

How? What does his cashiered worship mutter?

SECOND VARRO'S SERVANT

No matter what, he's poor, and that's revenge enough. Who can speak broader than he that has no house to put his head in? Such may rail against great buildings.

[Enter SERVILIUS.*]*

TITUS

O, here's Servilius; now we shall know some answer.

SERVILIUS

If I might beseech you, gentlemen, to repair some other hour, I should derive much from't. For take't of my soul, my lord leans wondrously to discontent. His comfortable temper has forsook him, he's much out of health and keeps his chamber.

LUCIUS

Many do keep their chambers are not sick.
And if it be so far beyond his health,
Methinks he should the sooner pay his debts
And make a clear way to the gods.

SERVILIUS

Good gods!

TITUS

We cannot take this for answer, sir.

FLAMINIUS

[Within.] Servilius, help! My lord, my lord!

[Enter TIMON *in a rage.]*

TIMON

What, are my doors opposed against my passage?
Have I been ever free, and must my house
Be my retentive enemy, my jail?
The place which I have feasted, does it now,
Like all mankind, show me an iron heart?

LUCIUS

Put in now, Titus.

TITUS

My lord, here is my bill.

LUCIUS

Here's mine.

HORTENSIUS

And mine, my lord.

BOTH VARRO'S SERVANTS

And ours, my lord.

PHILOTUS

All our bills.

TIMON

Knock me down with 'em! Cleave me to the girdle.

LUCIUS

Alas, my lord—

TIMON

Cut my heart in sums!

TITUS

Mine, fifty talents.

TIMON

Tell out my blood.

LUCIUS

Five thousand crowns, my lord.

TIMON

Five thousand drops pays that. What yours, and yours?

FIRST VARRO'S SERVANT

My lord—

SECOND VARRO'S SERVANT

My lord—

TIMON

Tear me, take me, and the gods fall upon you!

[Exit.]

HORTENSIUS

Faith, I perceive our masters may throw their caps at their money. These debts may well be called desperate ones, for a madman owes 'em.

[Exeunt.]

[Enter TIMON *and* FLAVIUS*.]*

TIMON

They have e'en put my breath from me, the slaves.
Creditors? Devils!

FLAVIUS

My dear lord—

TIMON

What if it should be so?

FLAVIUS

My lord—

TIMON

I'll have it so.—My steward!

FLAVIUS

Here, my lord.

TIMON

So fitly? Go, bid all my friends again,
Lucius, Lucullus, and Sempronius, all.
I'll once more feast the rascals.

FLAVIUS

O my lord,
You only speak from your distracted soul;
There is not so much left to furnish out
A moderate table.

TIMON

Be it not in thy care. Go,
I charge thee, invite them all. Let in the tide
Of knaves once more. My cook and I'll provide.

[Exeunt.]

Scene V. The same. The senate house

[Enter three SENATORS *at one door,* ALCIBIADES *meeting them, with* ATTENDANTS.*]*

FIRST SENATOR

My lord, you have my voice to 't. The fault's
Bloody. 'Tis necessary he should die.
Nothing emboldens sin so much as mercy.

SECOND SENATOR

Most true, the law shall bruise 'em.

ALCIBIADES

Honour, health, and compassion to the senate!

FIRST SENATOR

Now, captain?

ALCIBIADES

I am a humble suitor to your virtues,
For pity is the virtue of the law,
And none but tyrants use it cruelly.
It pleases time and fortune to lie heavy
Upon a friend of mine, who in hot blood
Hath stepped into the law, which is past depth
To those that without heed do plunge into't.
He is a man, setting his fate aside,
Of comely virtues,
Nor did he soil the fact with cowardice—
An honour in him which buys out his fault—
But with a noble fury and fair spirit,
Seeing his reputation touched to death,
He did oppose his foe;
And with such sober and unnoted passion
He did behave his anger, ere 'twas spent,
As if he had but proved an argument.

FIRST SENATOR

You undergo too strict a paradox,

Striving to make an ugly deed look fair.
Your words have took such pains as if they laboured
To bring manslaughter into form and set quarrelling
Upon the head of valour, which indeed
Is valour misbegot and came into the world
When sects and factions were newly born.
He's truly valiant that can wisely suffer
The worst that man can breathe, and make his wrongs
His outsides to wear them like his raiment, carelessly,
And ne'er prefer his injuries to his heart,
To bring it into danger.
If wrongs be evils and enforce us kill,
What folly 'tis to hazard life for ill!

ALCIBIADES

My lord—

FIRST SENATOR

You cannot make gross sins look clear.
To revenge is no valour, but to bear.

ALCIBIADES

My lords, then, under favour, pardon me
If I speak like a captain.
Why do fond men expose themselves to battle
And not endure all threats? Sleep upon't,
And let the foes quietly cut their throats
Without repugnancy? If there be
Such valour in the bearing, what make we
Abroad? Why, then, women are more valiant
That stay at home, if bearing carry it,
And the ass more captain than the lion, the felon
Loaden with irons wiser than the judge,
If wisdom be in suffering. O my lords,
As you are great, be pitifully good.
Who cannot condemn rashness in cold blood?
To kill, I grant, is sin's extremest gust,

But in defence, by mercy, 'tis most just.
To be in anger is impiety,
But who is man that is not angry?
Weigh but the crime with this.

SECOND SENATOR

You breathe in vain.

ALCIBIADES

In vain? His service done
At Lacedaemon and Byzantium
Were a sufficient briber for his life.

FIRST SENATOR

What's that?

ALCIBIADES

Why, I say, my lords, has done fair service
And slain in fight many of your enemies.
How full of valour did he bear himself
In the last conflict, and made plenteous wounds!

SECOND SENATOR

He has made too much plenty with 'em.
He's a sworn rioter. He has a sin
That often drowns him and takes his valour prisoner.
If there were no foes, that were enough
To overcome him. In that beastly fury,
He has been known to commit outrages
And cherish factions. 'Tis inferred to us
His days are foul and his drink dangerous.

FIRST SENATOR

He dies.

ALCIBIADES

Hard fate! He might have died in war.
My lords, if not for any parts in him,
Though his right arm might purchase his own time
And be in debt to none, yet, more to move you,
Take my deserts to his and join 'em both.
And, for I know your reverend ages love
Security, I'll pawn my victories, all
My honour, to you upon his good returns.
If by this crime he owes the law his life,
Why, let the war receive't in valiant gore,
For law is strict, and war is nothing more.

FIRST SENATOR

We are for law. He dies. Urge it no more,
On height of our displeasure. Friend or brother,
He forfeits his own blood that spills another.

ALCIBIADES

Must it be so? It must not be.
My lords, I do beseech you, know me.

SECOND SENATOR

How?

ALCIBIADES

Call me to your remembrances.

THIRD SENATOR

What?

ALCIBIADES

I cannot think but your age has forgot me,
It could not else be I should prove so base

To sue and be denied such common grace.
My wounds ache at you.

FIRST SENATOR

Do you dare our anger?
'Tis in few words, but spacious in effect:
We banish thee for ever.

ALCIBIADES

Banish me?
Banish your dotage, banish usury,
That makes the Senate ugly.

FIRST SENATOR

If, after two days' shine, Athens contain thee,
Attend our weightier judgment.
And, not to swell our spirit,
He shall be executed presently.

[Exeunt SENATORS.*]*

ALCIBIADES

Now the gods keep you old enough, that you may live
Only in bone, that none may look on you!
I'm worse than mad. I have kept back their foes
While they have told their money and let out
Their coin upon large interest, I myself
Rich only in large hurts. All those for this?
Is this the balsam that the usuring senate
Pours into captains' wounds? Banishment.
It comes not ill. I hate not to be banished.
It is a cause worthy my spleen and fury,
That I may strike at Athens. I'll cheer up
My discontented troops and lay for hearts.

'Tis honour with most lands to be at odds.
Soldiers should brook as little wrongs as gods.

[Exit.]

Scene VI. A room of state in Timon's house

[Music. Enter divers FRIENDS *at several doors.]*

FIRST FRIEND

The good time of day to you, sir.

SECOND FRIEND

I also wish it to you. I think this honourable lord did but try us this other day.

FIRST FRIEND

Upon that were my thoughts tiring when we encountered. I hope it is not so low with him as he made it seem in the trial of his several friends.

SECOND FRIEND

It should not be, by the persuasion of his new feasting.

FIRST FRIEND

I should think so. He hath sent me an earnest inviting, which many my near occasions did urge me to put off; but he hath conjured me beyond them, and I must needs appear.

SECOND FRIEND

In like manner was I in debt to my importunate business, but he would not hear my excuse. I am sorry, when he sent to borrow of me, that my provision was out.

FIRST FRIEND

I am sick of that grief too, as I understand how all things go.

SECOND FRIEND

Every man here's so. What would he have borrowed you?

FIRST FRIEND

A thousand pieces.

SECOND FRIEND

A thousand pieces!

FIRST FRIEND

What of you?

SECOND FRIEND

He sent to me, sir—here he comes.

[Enter TIMON *and* ATTENDANTS.*]*

TIMON

With all my heart, gentlemen both! And how fare you?

FIRST FRIEND

Ever at the best, hearing well of your lordship.

SECOND FRIEND

The swallow follows not summer more willing than we your lordship.

TIMON

[Aside.] Nor more willingly leaves winter, such summer birds are men. Gentlemen, our dinner will not recompense this long stay. Feast your ears with the music awhile, if they will fare so harshly o' th' trumpet's sound; we shall to't presently.

FIRST FRIEND

I hope it remains not unkindly with your lordship that I returned you an empty messenger.

TIMON

O, sir, let it not trouble you.

SECOND FRIEND

My noble lord—

TIMON

Ah, my good friend, what cheer?

SECOND FRIEND

My most honourable lord, I am e'en sick of shame that when your lordship this other day sent to me I was so unfortunate a beggar.

TIMON

Think not on't, sir.

SECOND FRIEND

If you had sent but two hours before—

TIMON

Let it not cumber your better remembrance.

[The banquet brought in.]

Come, bring in all together.

SECOND FRIEND

All covered dishes!

FIRST FRIEND

Royal cheer, I warrant you.

THIRD FRIEND

Doubt not that, if money and the season can yield it.

FIRST FRIEND

How do you? What's the news?

THIRD FRIEND

Alcibiades is banished. Hear you of it?

FIRST AND SECOND FRIENDS

Alcibiades banished?

THIRD FRIEND

'Tis so, be sure of it.

FIRST FRIEND

How, how?

SECOND FRIEND

I pray you, upon what?

TIMON

My worthy friends, will you draw near?

THIRD FRIEND

I'll tell you more anon. Here's a noble feast toward.

SECOND FRIEND

This is the old man still.

THIRD FRIEND

Will't hold, will't hold?

SECOND FRIEND

It does, but time will—and so—

THIRD FRIEND

I do conceive.

TIMON

Each man to his stool with that spur as he would to the lip of his mistress. Your diet shall be in all places alike. Make not a city feast of it, to let the meat cool ere we can agree upon the first place. Sit, sit. The gods require our thanks:

You great benefactors, sprinkle our society with thankfulness. For your own gifts make yourselves praised, but reserve still to give, lest your deities be despised. Lend to each man enough, that one need not lend to another; for, were your godheads to borrow of men, men would forsake the gods. Make the meat be beloved more than the man that gives it. Let no assembly of twenty be without a score of villains. If there sit twelve women at the table, let a dozen of them be as they are. The rest of your foes, O gods, the senators of Athens, together with the common lag of people, what is amiss in them, you gods, make suitable for destruction. For these my present friends, as they are to me nothing, so in nothing bless them, and to nothing are they welcome.

Uncover, dogs, and lap.

[The dishes are uncovered and prove to be full of lukewarm water.]

SOME SPEAK

What does his lordship mean?

SOME OTHER

I know not.

TIMON

May you a better feast never behold,
You knot of mouth-friends! Smoke and lukewarm water
Is your perfection. This is Timon's last,

Who, stuck and spangled with your flatteries,
Washes it off and sprinkles in your faces
Your reeking villainy.

[Throws water in their faces.]

Live loathed, and long, Most smiling, smooth, detested parasites, Courteous destroyers, affable wolves, meek bears, You fools of fortune, trencher-friends, time's flies, Cap-and-knee slaves, vapours, and minute-jacks! Of man and beast the infinite malady Crust you quite o'er! *[They stand.]* What, dost thou go? Soft! Take thy physic first; thou too, and thou! Stay, I will lend thee money, borrow none.

[He attacks them and forces them out.]

What, all in motion? Henceforth be no feast Whereat a villain's not a welcome guest. Burn, house! Sink Athens! Henceforth hated be Of Timon man and all humanity!

[Exit.]

[Enter TIMON*'s* FRIENDS*, the* SENATORS *with other* LORDS*.]*

FIRST FRIEND

How now, my lords?

SECOND FRIEND

Know you the quality of Lord Timon's fury?

THIRD FRIEND

Push! Did you see my cap?

FOURTH FRIEND

I have lost my gown.

FIRST FRIEND

He's but a mad lord, and nought but humours sways him. He gave me a jewel th' other day, and now he has beat it out of my hat. Did you see my jewel?

THIRD FRIEND

Did you see my cap?

SECOND FRIEND

Here 'tis.

FOURTH FRIEND

Here lies my gown.

FIRST FRIEND

Let's make no stay.

SECOND FRIEND

Lord Timon's mad.

THIRD FRIEND

I feel't upon my bones.

FOURTH FRIEND

One day he gives us diamonds, next day stones.

[Exeunt.]

Act IV

Scene I. Without the walls of Athens

[Enter TIMON.*]*

TIMON

Let me look back upon thee. O thou wall
That girdles in those wolves, dive in the earth
And fence not Athens! Matrons, turn incontinent!
Obedience fail in children! Slaves and fools,
Pluck the grave wrinkled senate from the bench
And minister in their steads! To general filths
Convert, o' th' instant, green virginity,
Do't in your parents' eyes! Bankrupts, hold fast;
Rather than render back, out with your knives
And cut your trusters' throats! Bound servants, steal!
Large-handed robbers your grave masters are,
And pill by law. Maid, to thy master's bed,
Thy mistress is o' th' brothel. Son of sixteen,
Pluck the lined crutch from thy old limping sire,
With it beat out his brains! Piety and fear,
Religion to the gods, peace, justice, truth,
Domestic awe, night-rest and neighbourhood,
Instruction, manners, mysteries and trades,
Degrees, observances, customs and laws,
Decline to your confounding contraries,

And let confusion live! Plagues incident to men,
Your potent and infectious fevers heap
On Athens, ripe for stroke! Thou cold sciatica,
Cripple our senators, that their limbs may halt
As lamely as their manners! Lust and liberty,
Creep in the minds and marrows of our youth,
That 'gainst the stream of virtue they may strive
And drown themselves in riot! Itches, blains,
Sow all th' Athenian bosoms, and their crop
Be general leprosy! Breath infect breath,
That their society, as their friendship, may
Be merely poison! Nothing I'll bear from thee
But nakedness, thou detestable town!
Take thou that too, with multiplying bans!
Timon will to the woods, where he shall find
Th' unkindest beast more kinder than mankind.
The gods confound—hear me, you good gods all!—
Th' Athenians both within and out that wall,
And grant, as Timon grows, his hate may grow
To the whole race of mankind, high and low!
Amen.

[Exit.]

Scene II. Athens. A room in Timon's house

[Enter FLAVIUS *with two or three* SERVANTS.*]*

FIRST SERVANT

Hear you, Master Steward, where's our master?
Are we undone, cast off, nothing remaining?

FLAVIUS

Alack, my fellows, what should I say to you?
Let me be recorded by the righteous gods,
I am as poor as you.

FIRST SERVANT

Such a house broke?
So noble a master fall'n? All gone, and not
One friend to take his fortune by the arm
And go along with him?

SECOND SERVANT

As we do turn our backs
From our companion, thrown into his grave,
So his familiars to his buried fortunes
Slink all away, leave their false vows with him,
Like empty purses picked; and his poor self,
A dedicated beggar to the air,
With his disease of all-shunned poverty,
Walks, like contempt, alone.—More of our fellows.

[Enter other SERVANTS.*]*

FLAVIUS

All broken implements of a ruined house.

THIRD SERVANT

Yet do our hearts wear Timon's livery.
That see I by our faces. We are fellows still,
Serving alike in sorrow. Leaked is our bark,
And we, poor mates, stand on the dying deck,
Hearing the surges threat. We must all part
Into this sea of air.

FLAVIUS

Good fellows all,
The latest of my wealth I'll share amongst you.
Wherever we shall meet, for Timon's sake
Let's yet be fellows. Let's shake our heads and say,
As 'twere a knell unto our master's fortune,
"We have seen better days." Let each take some.

[Offering them money.]

Nay, put out all your hands. Not one word more. Thus part we rich in sorrow, parting poor.

[They embrace and part several ways.]

O, the fierce wretchedness that glory brings us! Who would not wish to be from wealth exempt, Since riches point to misery and contempt? Who would be so mocked with glory, or to live But in a dream of friendship, To have his pomp and all what state compounds But only painted, like his varnished friends? Poor honest lord, brought low by his own heart, Undone by goodness! Strange, unusual blood When man's worst sin is he does too much good! Who then dares to be half so kind again? For bounty, that makes gods, does still mar men. My dearest lord, blessed to be most accursed, Rich only to be wretched, thy great fortunes Are made thy chief afflictions. Alas, kind lord, He's flung in rage from this ingrateful seat Of monstrous friends; Nor has he with him to supply his life, Or that which can command it. I'll follow and inquire him out. I'll ever serve his mind with my best will. Whilst I have gold, I'll be his steward still.

[Exit.]

Scene III. Woods and caves near the sea-shore

[Enter TIMON *in the woods.]*

TIMON

O blessed breeding sun, draw from the earth
Rotten humidity, below thy sister's orb
Infect the air! Twinned brothers of one womb,
Whose procreation, residence and birth
Scarce is dividant, touch them with several fortunes,
The greater scorns the lesser. Not nature,
To whom all sores lay siege, can bear great fortune
But by contempt of nature.
Raise me this beggar, and deny't that lord;
The senator shall bear contempt hereditary,
The beggar native honour.
It is the pasture lards the rother's sides,
The want that makes him lean. Who dares, who dares
In purity of manhood stand upright
And say, "This man's a flatterer"? If one be,
So are they all, for every grece of fortune
Is smoothed by that below. The learned pate
Ducks to the golden fool. All's obliquy.
There's nothing level in our cursed natures
But direct villainy. Therefore be abhorred
All feasts, societies, and throngs of men!
His semblable, yea, himself, Timon disdains.
Destruction fang mankind! Earth, yield me roots!

[Digs in the earth.]

Who seeks for better of thee, sauce his palate With thy most operant poison! What is here? Gold? Yellow, glittering, precious gold? No, gods, I am no idle votarist. Roots, you clear heavens! Thus much of this will make Black white, foul fair, wrong right, Base noble, old young, coward valiant. Ha, you gods, why this? What this, you gods? Why, this Will lug your priests and servants from your sides, Pluck stout men's pillows from below their heads. This yellow slave Will knit and break religions, bless th' accursed, Make the hoar leprosy adored, place thieves And give them title, knee, and approbation With senators on the bench. This is it That makes the wappened widow wed again; She whom the spittle-house and ulcerous sores Would cast the gorge at, this embalms and spices To th' April day again. Come, damned earth,

Thou common whore of mankind, that puts odds Among the rout of nations, I will make thee Do thy right nature.

[March afar off.]

Ha? A drum? Thou'rt quick, But yet I'll bury thee. Thou'lt go, strong thief, When gouty keepers of thee cannot stand. Nay, stay thou out for earnest.

[Keeping some gold.]

[Enter ALCIBIADES *with drum and fife, in warlike manner, and* PHRYNIA *and* TIMANDRA*.]*

ALCIBIADES

What art thou there? Speak.

TIMON

A beast, as thou art. The canker gnaw thy heart
For showing me again the eyes of man!

ALCIBIADES

What is thy name? Is man so hateful to thee
That art thyself a man?

TIMON

I am Misanthropos and hate mankind.
For thy part, I do wish thou wert a dog,
That I might love thee something.

ALCIBIADES

I know thee well,
But in thy fortunes am unlearned and strange.

TIMON

I know thee too, and more than that I know thee
I not desire to know. Follow thy drum,
With man's blood paint the ground gules, gules.
Religious canons, civil laws are cruel,
Then what should war be? This fell whore of thine
Hath in her more destruction than thy sword,
For all her cherubin look.

PHRYNIA

Thy lips rot off!

TIMON

I will not kiss thee, then the rot returns
To thine own lips again.

ALCIBIADES

How came the noble Timon to this change?

TIMON

As the moon does, by wanting light to give.
But then renew I could not like the moon;
There were no suns to borrow of.

ALCIBIADES

Noble Timon,
What friendship may I do thee?

TIMON

None, but to maintain my opinion.

ALCIBIADES

What is it, Timon?

TIMON

Promise me friendship, but perform none. If thou wilt not promise, the gods plague thee, for thou art a man. If thou dost perform, confound thee, for thou art a man.

ALCIBIADES

I have heard in some sort of thy miseries.

TIMON

Thou saw'st them when I had prosperity.

ALCIBIADES

I see them now; then was a blessed time.

TIMON

As thine is now, held with a brace of harlots.

TIMANDRA

Is this th' Athenian minion whom the world
Voiced so regardfully?

TIMON

Art thou Timandra?

TIMANDRA

Yes.

TIMON

Be a whore still, they love thee not that use thee;
Give them diseases, leaving with thee their lust.
Make use of thy salt hours. Season the slaves
For tubs and baths, bring down rose-cheeked youth
To the tub-fast and the diet.

TIMANDRA

Hang thee, monster!

ALCIBIADES

Pardon him, sweet Timandra, for his wits
Are drowned and lost in his calamities.
I have but little gold of late, brave Timon,
The want whereof doth daily make revolt
In my penurious band. I have heard and grieved
How cursed Athens, mindless of thy worth,
Forgetting thy great deeds when neighbour states,
But for thy sword and fortune, trod upon them—

TIMON

I prithee, beat thy drum and get thee gone.

ALCIBIADES

I am thy friend and pity thee, dear Timon.

TIMON

How dost thou pity him whom thou dost trouble?
I had rather be alone.

ALCIBIADES

Why, fare thee well.
Here is some gold for thee.

TIMON

Keep it, I cannot eat it.

ALCIBIADES

When I have laid proud Athens on a heap—

TIMON

Warr'st thou 'gainst Athens?

ALCIBIADES

Ay, Timon, and have cause.

TIMON

The gods confound them all in thy conquest,
And thee after, when thou hast conquered!

ALCIBIADES

Why me, Timon?

TIMON

That by killing of villains
Thou wast born to conquer my country.
Put up thy gold. Go on, here's gold, go on.
Be as a planetary plague when Jove
Will o'er some high-viced city hang his poison
In the sick air. Let not thy sword skip one.
Pity not honoured age for his white beard;
He is an usurer. Strike me the counterfeit matron;
It is her habit only that is honest,
Herself's a bawd. Let not the virgin's cheek
Make soft thy trenchant sword, for those milk paps
That through the window-bars bore at men's eyes,
Are not within the leaf of pity writ,
But set them down horrible traitors. Spare not the babe,
Whose dimpled smiles from fools exhaust their mercy;
Think it a bastard whom the oracle
Hath doubtfully pronounced thy throat shall cut,
And mince it sans remorse. Swear against objects;
Put armour on thine ears and on thine eyes,
Whose proof nor yells of mothers, maids, nor babes,
Nor sight of priests in holy vestments bleeding,
Shall pierce a jot. There's gold to pay thy soldiers.

Make large confusion and, thy fury spent,
Confounded be thyself! Speak not, be gone.

ALCIBIADES

Hast thou gold yet? I'll take the gold thou giv'st me,
Not all thy counsel.

TIMON

Dost thou or dost thou not, heaven's curse upon thee!

PHRYNIA AND TIMANDRA

Give us some gold, good Timon.
Hast thou more?

TIMON

Enough to make a whore forswear her trade,
And to make whores a bawd. Hold up, you sluts,
Your aprons mountant. You are not oathable,
Although I know you'll swear—terribly swear
Into strong shudders and to heavenly agues
Th' immortal gods that hear you. Spare your oaths,
I'll trust to your conditions. Be whores still,
And he whose pious breath seeks to convert you,
Be strong in whore, allure him, burn him up;
Let your close fire predominate his smoke,
And be no turncoats. Yet may your pains six months,
Be quite contrary. And thatch your poor thin roofs
With burdens of the dead—some that were hanged,
No matter; wear them, betray with them. Whore still,
Paint till a horse may mire upon your face.
A pox of wrinkles!

PHRYNIA AND TIMANDRA

Well, more gold. What then?
Believe't that we'll do anything for gold.

TIMON

Consumptions sow
In hollow bones of man; strike their sharp shins,
And mar men's spurring. Crack the lawyer's voice,
That he may never more false title plead
Nor sound his quillets shrilly. Hoar the flamen,
That scolds against the quality of flesh
And not believes himself. Down with the nose,
Down with it flat, take the bridge quite away
Of him that, his particular to foresee,
Smells from the general weal. Make curled-pate ruffians
bald,
And let the unscarred braggarts of the war
Derive some pain from you. Plague all,
That your activity may defeat and quell
The source of all erection. There's more gold.
Do you damn others, and let this damn you,
And ditches grave you all!

PHRYNIA AND TIMANDRA

More counsel with more money, bounteous Timon.

TIMON

More whore, more mischief first! I have given you earnest.

ALCIBIADES

Strike up the drum towards Athens. Farewell, Timon.
If I thrive well, I'll visit thee again.

TIMON

If I hope well, I'll never see thee more.

ALCIBIADES

I never did thee harm.

TIMON

Yes, thou spok'st well of me.

ALCIBIADES

Call'st thou that harm?

TIMON

Men daily find it. Get thee away, and take
Thy beagles with thee.

ALCIBIADES

We but offend him. Strike.

[Drum beats. Exeunt all but TIMON.*]*

TIMON

That nature, being sick of man's unkindness,
Should yet be hungry! *[He digs.]* Common mother, thou,
Whose womb unmeasurable and infinite breast
Teems and feeds all; whose selfsame mettle
Whereof thy proud child, arrogant man, is puffed,
Engenders the black toad and adder blue,
The gilded newt and eyeless venomed worm,
With all the abhorred births below crisp heaven
Whereon Hyperion's quickening fire doth shine:
Yield him who all thy human sons doth hate,
From forth thy plenteous bosom, one poor root!
Ensear thy fertile and conceptious womb,
Let it no more bring out ingrateful man.
Go great with tigers, dragons, wolves, and bears;
Teem with new monsters, whom thy upward face
Hath to the marbled mansion all above
Never presented. O, a root, dear thanks!
Dry up thy marrows, vines and plough-torn leas,
Whereof ingrateful man, with liquorish draughts
And morsels unctuous greases his pure mind,
That from it all consideration slips—

[Enter APEMANTUS.*]*

More man? Plague, plague!

APEMANTUS

I was directed hither. Men report
Thou dost affect my manners and dost use them.

TIMON

'Tis, then, because thou dost not keep a dog
Whom I would imitate. Consumption catch thee!

APEMANTUS

This is in thee a nature but infected,
A poor unmanly melancholy sprung
From change of fortune. Why this spade, this place?
This slave-like habit and these looks of care?
Thy flatterers yet wear silk, drink wine, lie soft,
Hug their diseased perfumes, and have forgot
That ever Timon was. Shame not these woods
By putting on the cunning of a carper.
Be thou a flatterer now, and seek to thrive
By that which has undone thee. Hinge thy knee
And let his very breath whom thou'lt observe
Blow off thy cap; praise his most vicious strain,
And call it excellent. Thou wast told thus;
Thou gav'st thine ears, like tapsters that bade welcome,
To knaves and all approachers. 'Tis most just
That thou turn rascal; had'st thou wealth again,
Rascals should have't. Do not assume my likeness.

TIMON

Were I like thee, I'd throw away myself.

APEMANTUS

Thou hast cast away thyself, being like thyself
A madman so long, now a fool. What, think'st
That the bleak air, thy boisterous chamberlain,
Will put thy shirt on warm? Will these mossed trees,
That have outlived the eagle, page thy heels
And skip when thou point'st out? Will the cold brook,
Candied with ice, caudle thy morning taste
To cure thy o'ernight's surfeit? Call the creatures
Whose naked natures live in all the spite
Of wreakful heaven, whose bare unhoused trunks,
To the conflicting elements exposed,
Answer mere nature, bid them flatter thee.
O, thou shalt find—

TIMON

A fool of thee. Depart.

APEMANTUS

I love thee better now than e'er I did.

TIMON

I hate thee worse.

APEMANTUS

Why?

TIMON

Thou flatter'st misery.

APEMANTUS

I flatter not, but say thou art a caitiff.

TIMON

Why dost thou seek me out?

APEMANTUS

To vex thee.

TIMON

Always a villain's office or a fool's.
Dost please thyself in't?

APEMANTUS

Ay.

TIMON

What, a knave too?

APEMANTUS

If thou didst put this sour cold habit on
To castigate thy pride, 'twere well; but thou
Dost it enforcedly. Thou'dst courtier be again
Wert thou not beggar. Willing misery
Outlives incertain pomp, is crowned before;
The one is filling still, never complete,
The other, at high wish. Best state, contentless,
Hath a distracted and most wretched being,
Worse than the worst, content.
Thou shouldst desire to die, being miserable.

TIMON

Not by his breath that is more miserable.
Thou art a slave whom Fortune's tender arm
With favour never clasped, but bred a dog.
Hadst thou, like us from our first swath, proceeded
The sweet degrees that this brief world affords
To such as may the passive drugs of it
Freely command, thou wouldst have plunged thyself
In general riot, melted down thy youth
In different beds of lust and never learned

The icy precepts of respect, but followed
The sugared game before thee. But myself—
Who had the world as my confectionary,
The mouths, the tongues, the eyes and hearts of men
At duty, more than I could frame employment,
That numberless upon me stuck as leaves
Do on the oak, have with one winter's brush
Fell from their boughs and left me open, bare
For every storm that blows—I to bear this,
That never knew but better, is some burden.
Thy nature did commence in sufferance, time
Hath made thee hard in't. Why shouldst thou hate men?
They never flattered thee. What hast thou given?
If thou wilt curse, thy father, that poor rag,
Must be thy subject, who in spite put stuff
To some she-beggar and compounded thee
Poor rogue hereditary. Hence, be gone!
If thou hadst not been born the worst of men,
Thou hadst been a knave and flatterer.

APEMANTUS

Art thou proud yet?

TIMON

Ay, that I am not thee.

APEMANTUS

I, that I was no prodigal.

TIMON

I, that I am one now.
Were all the wealth I have shut up in thee,
I'd give thee leave to hang it. Get thee gone.
That the whole life of Athens were in this!
Thus would I eat it.

[Eats a root.]

APEMANTUS

Here, I will mend thy feast.

TIMON

First mend my company, take away thyself.

APEMANTUS

So I shall mend mine own, by th' lack of thine.

TIMON

'Tis not well mended so, it is but botched.
If not, I would it were.

APEMANTUS

What wouldst thou have to Athens?

TIMON

Thee thither in a whirlwind. If thou wilt,
Tell them there I have gold. Look, so I have.

APEMANTUS

Here is no use for gold.

TIMON

The best and truest,
For here it sleeps and does no hired harm.

APEMANTUS

Where liest a-nights, Timon?

TIMON

Under that's above me. Where feed'st thou a-days, Apemantus?

APEMANTUS

Where my stomach finds meat, or rather where I eat it.

TIMON

Would poison were obedient and knew my mind!

APEMANTUS

Where wouldst thou send it?

TIMON

To sauce thy dishes.

APEMANTUS

The middle of humanity thou never knewest, but the extremity of both ends. When thou wast in thy gilt and thy perfume, they mocked thee for too much curiosity; in thy rags thou know'st none, but art despised for the contrary. There's a medlar for thee. Eat it.

TIMON

On what I hate I feed not.

APEMANTUS

Dost hate a medlar?

TIMON

Ay, though it look like thee.

APEMANTUS

An thou'dst hated medlars sooner, thou shouldst have loved thyself better now. What man didst thou ever know unthrift that was beloved after his means?

TIMON

Who, without those means thou talk'st of, didst thou ever know beloved?

APEMANTUS

Myself.

TIMON

I understand thee. Thou hadst some means to keep a dog.

APEMANTUS

What things in the world canst thou nearest compare to thy flatterers?

TIMON

Women nearest; but men—men are the things themselves. What wouldst thou do with the world, Apemantus, if it lay in thy power?

APEMANTUS

Give it the beasts, to be rid of the men.

TIMON

Wouldst thou have thyself fall in the confusion of men and remain a beast with the beasts?

APEMANTUS

Ay, Timon.

TIMON

A beastly ambition, which the gods grant thee t' attain to. If thou wert the lion, the fox would beguile thee; if thou wert the lamb, the fox would eat thee; if thou wert the fox, the lion would suspect thee when peradventure thou wert accused by the ass; if thou wert the ass, thy dulness would torment thee, and still thou lived'st but as a breakfast to the wolf; if thou wert the wolf, thy greediness would afflict thee, and oft thou shouldst hazard thy life for thy dinner. Wert thou the unicorn, pride and wrath would confound thee and make thine own self the conquest of thy fury; wert thou a bear, thou wouldst be killed by the horse; wert thou a horse, thou wouldst be seized by the leopard; wert thou a leopard, thou wert germane to the lion, and the spots of thy kindred were jurors on thy life. All thy safety were remotion, and thy defence absence. What beast couldst thou be that were not subject to a beast? And what beast art thou already that seest not thy loss in transformation!

APEMANTUS

If thou couldst please me with speaking to me, thou mightst have hit upon it here. The commonwealth of Athens is become a forest of beasts.

TIMON

How has the ass broke the wall, that thou art out of the city?

APEMANTUS

Yonder comes a poet and a painter. The plague of company light upon thee! I will fear to catch it, and give way. When I know not what else to do, I'll see thee again.

TIMON

When there is nothing living but thee, thou shalt be welcome. I had rather be a beggar's dog than Apemantus.

APEMANTUS

Thou art the cap of all the fools alive.

TIMON

Would thou wert clean enough to spit upon!

APEMANTUS

A plague on thee! Thou art too bad to curse.

TIMON

All villains that do stand by thee are pure.

APEMANTUS

There is no leprosy but what thou speak'st.

TIMON

If I name thee,
I'll beat thee, but I should infect my hands.

APEMANTUS

I would my tongue could rot them off!

TIMON

Away, thou issue of a mangy dog!
Choler does kill me that thou art alive.
I swoon to see thee.

APEMANTUS

Would thou wouldst burst!

TIMON

Away, thou tedious rogue!
I am sorry I shall lose a stone by thee.

[Throws a stone at him.]

APEMANTUS

Beast!

TIMON

Slave!

APEMANTUS

Toad!

TIMON

Rogue, rogue, rogue!
I am sick of this false world, and will love nought
But even the mere necessities upon't.
Then, Timon, presently prepare thy grave.
Lie where the light foam of the sea may beat
Thy gravestone daily. Make thine epitaph,
That death in me at others' lives may laugh.
[To the gold.] O thou sweet king-killer and dear divorce

'Twixt natural son and sire; thou bright defiler
Of Hymen's purest bed, thou valiant Mars;
Thou ever young, fresh, loved, and delicate wooer,
Whose blush doth thaw the consecrated snow
That lies on Dian's lap; thou visible god,
That solder'st close impossibilities
And mak'st them kiss, that speak'st with every tongue
To every purpose! O thou touch of hearts,
Think thy slave man rebels, and by thy virtue
Set them into confounding odds, that beasts
May have the world in empire!

APEMANTUS

Would 'twere so!
But not till I am dead. I'll say thou'st gold;
Thou wilt be thronged to shortly.

TIMON

Thronged to?

APEMANTUS

Ay.

TIMON

Thy back, I prithee.

APEMANTUS

Live and love thy misery.

TIMON

Long live so, and so die! I am quit.

APEMANTUS

More things like men. Eat, Timon, and abhor them.

[Exit APEMANTUS.*]*

[Enter BANDITTI.*]*

FIRST BANDIT

Where should he have this gold? It is some poor fragment, some slender ort of his remainder. The mere want of gold and the falling-from of his friends drove him into this melancholy.

SECOND BANDIT

It is noised he hath a mass of treasure.

THIRD BANDIT

Let us make the assay upon him. If he care not for't, he will supply us easily; if he covetously reserve it, how shall's get it?

SECOND BANDIT

True, for he bears it not about him. 'Tis hid.

FIRST BANDIT

Is not this he?

BANDITTI

Where?

SECOND BANDIT

'Tis his description.

THIRD BANDIT

He; I know him.

BANDITTI

Save thee, Timon!

TIMON

Now, thieves?

BANDITTI

Soldiers, not thieves.

TIMON

Both too, and women's sons.

BANDITTI

We are not thieves, but men that much do want.

TIMON

Your greatest want is, you want much of meat.
Why should you want? Behold, the earth hath roots,
Within this mile break forth a hundred springs,
The oaks bear mast, the briars scarlet hips,
The bounteous housewife Nature on each bush
Lays her full mess before you. Want? Why want?

FIRST BANDIT

We cannot live on grass, on berries, water,
As beasts and birds and fishes.

TIMON

Nor on the beasts themselves, the birds, and fishes;
You must eat men. Yet thanks I must you con
That you are thieves professed, that you work not
In holier shapes, for there is boundless theft
In limited professions. Rascal thieves,
Here's gold. Go, suck the subtle blood o' th' grape
Till the high fever seethe your blood to froth,
And so scape hanging. Trust not the physician;
His antidotes are poison, and he slays
More than you rob. Take wealth and lives together,
Do villainy, do, since you protest to do't,
Like workmen. I'll example you with thievery.
The sun's a thief and with his great attraction
Robs the vast sea; the moon's an arrant thief,
And her pale fire she snatches from the sun;
The sea's a thief, whose liquid surge resolves
The moon into salt tears; the earth's a thief,

That feeds and breeds by a composture stol'n
From general excrement. Each thing's a thief.
The laws, your curb and whip, in their rough power
Has unchecked theft. Love not yourselves; away!
Rob one another. There's more gold. Cut throats,
All that you meet are thieves. To Athens go,
Break open shops, nothing can you steal
But thieves do lose it. Steal no less for this I give you,
And gold confound you howsoe'er! Amen.

THIRD BANDIT

Has almost charmed me from my profession by persuading me to it.

FIRST BANDIT

'Tis in the malice of mankind that he thus advises us, not to have us thrive in our mystery.

SECOND BANDIT

I'll believe him as an enemy and give over my trade.

FIRST BANDIT

Let us first see peace in Athens. There is no time so miserable but a man may be true.

[Exeunt BANDITTI.*]*

[Enter FLAVIUS.*]*

FLAVIUS

O you gods!
Is yond despised and ruinous man my lord?
Full of decay and failing? O monument
And wonder of good deeds evilly bestowed!
What an alteration of honour has desperate want made!
What viler thing upon the earth than friends
Who can bring noblest minds to basest ends!
How rarely does it meet with this time's guise,

When man was wished to love his enemies!
Grant I may ever love, and rather woo
Those that would mischief me than those that do!
He has caught me in his eye. I will present
My honest grief unto him and as my lord
Still serve him with my life.—My dearest master!

TIMON

Away! What art thou?

FLAVIUS

Have you forgot me, sir?

TIMON

Why dost ask that? I have forgot all men.
Then, if thou grant'st thou'rt a man, I have forgot thee.

FLAVIUS

An honest poor servant of yours.

TIMON

Then I know thee not.
I never had honest man about me. I; all
I kept were knaves to serve in meat to villains.

FLAVIUS

The gods are witness,
Ne'er did poor steward wear a truer grief
For his undone lord than mine eyes for you.

TIMON

What, dost thou weep? Come nearer then. I love thee
Because thou art a woman and disclaim'st
Flinty mankind, whose eyes do never give

But thorough lust and laughter. Pity's sleeping.
Strange times that weep with laughing, not with weeping!

FLAVIUS

I beg of you to know me, good my lord,
T' accept my grief, and whilst this poor wealth lasts
To entertain me as your steward still.

TIMON

Had I a steward
So true, so just, and now so comfortable?
It almost turns my dangerous nature mild.
Let me behold thy face. Surely this man
Was born of woman.
Forgive my general and exceptless rashness,
You perpetual sober gods! I do proclaim
One honest man, mistake me not, but one;
No more, I pray, and he's a steward.
How fain would I have hated all mankind,
And thou redeem'st thyself. But all, save thee,
I fell with curses.
Methinks thou art more honest now than wise,
For by oppressing and betraying me
Thou mightst have sooner got another service;
For many so arrive at second masters
Upon their first lord's neck. But tell me true—
For I must ever doubt, though ne'er so sure—
Is not thy kindness subtle, covetous,
A usuring kindness and as rich men deal gifts,
Expecting in return twenty for one?

FLAVIUS

No, my most worthy master, in whose breast
Doubt and suspect, alas, are placed too late.
You should have feared false times when you did feast,

Suspect still comes where an estate is least.
That which I show, heaven knows, is merely love,
Duty and zeal to your unmatched mind,
Care of your food and living. And believe it,
My most honoured lord,
For any benefit that points to me,
Either in hope or present, I'd exchange
For this one wish, that you had power and wealth
To requite me by making rich yourself.

TIMON

Look thee, 'tis so! Thou singly honest man,
Here, take. The gods out of my misery
Have sent thee treasure. Go, live rich and happy,
But thus conditioned: thou shalt build from men;
Hate all, curse all, show charity to none,
But let the famished flesh slide from the bone
Ere thou relieve the beggar; give to dogs
What thou deniest to men; let prisons swallow 'em,
Debts wither 'em to nothing; be men like blasted woods,
And may diseases lick up their false bloods!
And so farewell and thrive.

FLAVIUS

O, let me stay
And comfort you, my master.

TIMON

If thou hat'st curses,
Stay not. Fly whilst thou'rt blest and free.
Ne'er see thou man, and let me ne'er see thee.

[Exeunt severally.]

Act V

Scene I. The woods. Before Timon's cave

[Enter POET *and* PAINTER.*]*

PAINTER

As I took note of the place, it cannot be far where he abides.

POET

What's to be thought of him? Does the rumour hold for true that he is so full of gold?

PAINTER

Certain. Alcibiades reports it; Phrynia and Timandra had gold of him. He likewise enriched poor straggling soldiers with great quantity. 'Tis said he gave unto his steward a mighty sum.

POET

Then this breaking of his has been but a try for his friends?

PAINTER

Nothing else. You shall see him a palm in Athens again, and flourish with the highest. Therefore 'tis not amiss we tender our loves to him in this supposed distress of his. It will show honestly in us and is very likely to load our purposes with what they travail for, if it be a just and true report that goes of his having.

POET

What have you now to present unto him?

PAINTER

Nothing at this time but my visitation; only I will promise him an excellent piece.

POET

I must serve him so too, tell him of an intent that's coming toward him.

PAINTER

Good as the best. Promising is the very air o' th' time; it opens the eyes of expectation. Performance is ever the duller for his act and, but in the plainer and simpler kind of people, the deed of saying is quite out of use. To promise is most courtly and fashionable; performance is a kind of will or testament which argues a great sickness in his judgment that makes it.

[Enter TIMON *from his cave.]*

TIMON

[Aside.] Excellent workman! Thou canst not paint a man so bad as is thyself.

POET

I am thinking what I shall say I have provided for him. It must be a personating of himself, a satire against the softness of prosperity, with a discovery of the infinite flatteries that follow youth and opulency.

TIMON

[Aside.] Must thou needs stand for a villain in thine own work? Wilt thou whip thine own faults in other men? Do so, I have gold for thee.

POET

Nay, let's seek him.
Then do we sin against our own estate
When we may profit meet and come too late.

PAINTER

True.
When the day serves, before black-cornered night,
Find what thou want'st by free and offered light.
Come.

TIMON

[Aside.] I'll meet you at the turn. What a god's gold,
That he is worshipped in a baser temple
Than where swine feed!
'Tis thou that rigg'st the bark and plough'st the foam,
Settlest admired reverence in a slave.
To thee be worship, and thy saints for aye
Be crowned with plagues, that thee alone obey!
Fit I meet them.

[He comes forward.]

POET

Hail, worthy Timon!

PAINTER

Our late noble master!

TIMON

Have I once lived to see two honest men?

POET

Sir,
Having often of your open bounty tasted,
Hearing you were retired, your friends fall'n off,

Whose thankless natures—O abhorred spirits!
Not all the whips of heaven are large enough—
What, to you,
Whose star-like nobleness gave life and influence
To their whole being? I am rapt and cannot cover
The monstrous bulk of this ingratitude
With any size of words.

TIMON

Let it go naked. Men may see't the better.
You that are honest, by being what you are,
Make them best seen and known.

PAINTER

He and myself
Have travailed in the great shower of your gifts,
And sweetly felt it.

TIMON

Ay, you are honest men.

PAINTER

We are hither come to offer you our service.

TIMON

Most honest men! Why, how shall I requite you?
Can you eat roots and drink cold water? No?

BOTH

What we can do we'll do, to do you service.

TIMON

Ye're honest men. Ye've heard that I have gold,
I am sure you have. Speak truth, you're honest men.

PAINTER

So it is said, my noble lord; but therefore
Came not my friend nor I.

TIMON

Good honest men! *[To* PAINTER.*]* Thou draw'st a counterfeit
Best in all Athens. Thou'rt indeed the best,
Thou counterfeit'st most lively.

PAINTER

So so, my lord.

TIMON

E'en so, sir, as I say. *[To the* POET.*]* And for thy fiction,
Why, thy verse swells with stuff so fine and smooth
That thou art even natural in thine art.
But for all this, my honest-natured friends,
I must needs say you have a little fault.
Marry, 'tis not monstrous in you, neither wish I
You take much pains to mend.

BOTH

Beseech your honour
To make it known to us.

TIMON

You'll take it ill.

BOTH

Most thankfully, my lord.

TIMON

Will you indeed?

BOTH

Doubt it not, worthy lord.

TIMON

There's never a one of you but trusts a knave
That mightily deceives you.

BOTH

Do we, my lord?

TIMON

Ay, and you hear him cog, see him dissemble,
Know his gross patchery, love him, feed him,
Keep in your bosom, yet remain assured
That he's a made-up villain.

PAINTER

I know not such, my lord.

POET

Nor I.

TIMON

Look you, I love you well. I'll give you gold.
Rid me these villains from your companies,
Hang them or stab them, drown them in a draught,
Confound them by some course, and come to me,
I'll give you gold enough.

BOTH

Name them, my lord, let's know them.

TIMON

You that way, and you this, but two in company.
Each man apart, all single and alone,
Yet an arch-villain keeps him company.
[To one.] If where thou art, two villians shall not be,
Come not near him. *[To the other.]* If thou wouldst not reside
But where one villain is, then him abandon.
Hence, pack! There's gold. You came for gold, ye slaves.
[To one.] You have work for me, there's payment, hence!
[To the other.] You are an alchemist; make gold of that.
Out, rascal dogs!

*[*TIMON *drives them out and then retires to his cave]*

Scene II. The same

[Enter FLAVIUS *and two* SENATORS.*]*

FLAVIUS

It is vain that you would speak with Timon.
For he is set so only to himself
That nothing but himself which looks like man
Is friendly with him.

FIRST SENATOR

Bring us to his cave.
It is our part and promise to th' Athenians
To speak with Timon.

SECOND SENATOR

At all times alike
Men are not still the same: 'twas time and griefs
That framed him thus. Time, with his fairer hand,
Offering the fortunes of his former days,
The former man may make him. Bring us to him
And chance it as it may.

FLAVIUS

Here is his cave.
Peace and content be here! Lord Timon! Timon,
Look out and speak to friends. The Athenians
By two of their most reverend senate greet thee.
Speak to them, noble Timon.

[Enter TIMON *out of his cave.]*

TIMON

Thou sun that comforts, burn! Speak and be hanged!
For each true word, a blister, and each false
Be as a cantherizing to the root o' th' tongue,
Consuming it with speaking.

FIRST SENATOR

Worthy Timon—

TIMON

Of none but such as you, and you of Timon.

FIRST SENATOR

The senators of Athens greet thee, Timon.

TIMON

[Aside.] I thank them and would send them back the
plague,
Could I but catch it for them.

FIRST SENATOR

O, forget
What we are sorry for ourselves in thee.
The senators with one consent of love
Entreat thee back to Athens, who have thought
On special dignities, which vacant lie
For thy best use and wearing.

SECOND SENATOR

They confess
Toward thee forgetfulness too general gross,
Which now the public body, which doth seldom
Play the recanter, feeling in itself
A lack of Timon's aid, hath sense withal
Of its own fall, restraining aid to Timon,
And send forth us to make their sorrowed render,
Together with a recompense more fruitful
Than their offence can weigh down by the dram,
Ay, even such heaps and sums of love and wealth,
As shall to thee blot out what wrongs were theirs,
And write in thee the figures of their love,
Ever to read them thine.

TIMON

You witch me in it,
Surprise me to the very brink of tears.
Lend me a fool's heart and a woman's eyes
And I'll beweep these comforts, worthy senators.

FIRST SENATOR

Therefore so please thee to return with us,
And of our Athens, thine and ours, to take
The captainship, thou shalt be met with thanks,
Allowed with absolute power, and thy good name
Live with authority. So soon we shall drive back
Of Alcibiades th' approaches wild,
Who like a boar too savage doth root up
His country's peace.

SECOND SENATOR

And shakes his threatening sword
Against the walls of Athens.

FIRST SENATOR

Therefore, Timon—

TIMON

Well, sir, I will. Therefore I will, sir, thus:
If Alcibiades kill my countrymen,
Let Alcibiades know this of Timon,
That Timon cares not. But if he sack fair Athens
And take our goodly aged men by th' beards,
Giving our holy virgins to the stain
Of contumelious, beastly, mad-brained war,
Then let him know, and tell him Timon speaks it,
In pity of our aged and our youth,
I cannot choose but tell him that I care not;
And—let him take't at worst—for their knives care not
While you have throats to answer. For myself,
There's not a whittle in th' unruly camp
But I do prize it at my love before
The reverend'st throat in Athens. So I leave you
To the protection of the prosperous gods,
As thieves to keepers.

FLAVIUS

Stay not, all's in vain.

TIMON

Why, I was writing of my epitaph;
It will be seen tomorrow. My long sickness
Of health and living now begins to mend
And nothing brings me all things. Go, live still,
Be Alcibiades your plague, you his,
And last so long enough.

FIRST SENATOR

We speak in vain.

TIMON

But yet I love my country and am not
One that rejoices in the common wrack,
As common bruit doth put it.

FIRST SENATOR

That's well spoke.

TIMON

Commend me to my loving countrymen.

FIRST SENATOR

These words become your lips as they pass through them.

SECOND SENATOR

And enter in our ears like great triumphers
In their applauding gates.

TIMON

Commend me to them,
And tell them that to ease them of their griefs,
Their fears of hostile strokes, their aches, losses,
Their pangs of love, with other incident throes
That nature's fragile vessel doth sustain
In life's uncertain voyage, I will some kindness do them;
I'll teach them to prevent wild Alcibiades' wrath.

FIRST SENATOR

[Aside.] I like this well, he will return again.

TIMON

I have a tree which grows here in my close
That mine own use invites me to cut down,
And shortly must I fell it. Tell my friends,
Tell Athens, in the sequence of degree
From high to low throughout, that whoso please
To stop affliction, let him take his haste,
Come hither ere my tree hath felt the axe
And hang himself. I pray you do my greeting.

FLAVIUS

Trouble him no further; thus you still shall find him.

TIMON

Come not to me again, but say to Athens
Timon hath made his everlasting mansion
Upon the beached verge of the salt flood,
Who once a day with his embossed froth
The turbulent surge shall cover; thither come,
And let my gravestone be your oracle.
Lips, let sour words go by, and language end:
What is amiss, plague and infection mend;
Graves only be men's works and death their gain,
Sun, hide thy beams, Timon hath done his reign.

[Exit TIMON *into his cave.]*

FIRST SENATOR

His discontents are unremovably
Coupled to nature.

SECOND SENATOR

Our hope in him is dead. Let us return
And strain what other means is left unto us
In our dear peril.

FIRST SENATOR

It requires swift foot.

[Exeunt.]

Scene III. Before the walls of Athens

[Enter two other SENATORS*, with a* MESSENGER*.]*

FIRST SENATOR

Thou hast painfully discovered. Are his files
As full as thy report?

MESSENGER

I have spoke the least.
Besides, his expedition promises
Present approach.

SECOND SENATOR

We stand much hazard if they bring not Timon.

MESSENGER

I met a courier, one mine ancient friend,
Whom, though in general part we were opposed,
Yet our old love made a particular force
And made us speak like friends. This man was riding
From Alcibiades to Timon's cave
With letters of entreaty, which imported
His fellowship i' th' cause against your city,
In part for his sake moved.

[Enter the other SENATORS *from* TIMON.*]*

THIRD SENATOR

Here come our brothers.

FIRST SENATOR

No talk of Timon, nothing of him expect.
The enemy's drum is heard, and fearful scouring
Doth choke the air with dust. In, and prepare.
Ours is the fall, I fear, our foe's the snare.

[Exeunt.]

Scene IV. The woods. Timon's cave, and a rude tomb seen

[Enter a SOLDIER *in the woods, seeking* TIMON.*]*

SOLDIER

By all description this should be the place.
Who's here? Speak, ho! No answer? What is this?
Timon is dead, who hath outstretched his span.
Some beast read this; there does not live a man.
Dead, sure, and this his grave. What's on this tomb
I cannot read. The character I'll take with wax.
Our captain hath in every figure skill,
An aged interpreter, though young in days.
Before proud Athens he's set down by this,
Whose fall the mark of his ambition is.

[Exit.]

Scene V. Before the walls of Athens

[Trumpets sound. Enter ALCIBIADES *with his powers before Athens.]*

ALCIBIADES

Sound to this coward and lascivious town
Our terrible approach.

[A parley sounds.]

[The SENATORS *appear upon the walls.]*

Till now you have gone on and filled the time With all licentious measure, making your wills The scope of justice. Till now myself and such As slept within the shadow of your power Have wandered with our traversed arms, and breathed Our sufferance vainly. Now the time is flush, When crouching marrow, in the bearer strong Cries of itself, "No more!" Now breathless wrong Shall sit and pant in your great chairs of ease, And pursy insolence shall break his wind With fear and horrid flight.

FIRST SENATOR

Noble and young,
When thy first griefs were but a mere conceit,
Ere thou hadst power or we had cause of fear,
We sent to thee to give thy rages balm,
To wipe out our ingratitude with loves
Above their quantity.

SECOND SENATOR

So did we woo
Transformed Timon to our city's love
By humble message and by promised means.
We were not all unkind, nor all deserve
The common stroke of war.

FIRST SENATOR

These walls of ours
Were not erected by their hands from whom
You have received your griefs; nor are they such
That these great towers, trophies, and schools should fall
For private faults in them.

SECOND SENATOR

Nor are they living
Who were the motives that you first went out.
Shame, that they wanted cunning, in excess
Hath broke their hearts. March, noble lord,
Into our city with thy banners spread.
By decimation and a tithed death,
If thy revenges hunger for that food
Which nature loathes, take thou the destined tenth,
And by the hazard of the spotted die
Let die the spotted.

FIRST SENATOR

All have not offended.
For those that were, it is not square to take,
On those that are, revenge. Crimes, like lands,
Are not inherited. Then, dear countryman,
Bring in thy ranks but leave without thy rage;
Spare thy Athenian cradle and those kin
Which in the bluster of thy wrath must fall
With those that have offended. Like a shepherd
Approach the fold and cull th' infected forth,
But kill not all together.

SECOND SENATOR

What thou wilt,
Thou rather shalt enforce it with thy smile
Than hew to 't with thy sword.

FIRST SENATOR

Set but thy foot
Against our rampired gates and they shall ope,
So thou wilt send thy gentle heart before
To say thou'lt enter friendly.

SECOND SENATOR

Throw thy glove,
Or any token of thine honour else,
That thou wilt use the wars as thy redress
And not as our confusion, all thy powers
Shall make their harbour in our town till we
Have sealed thy full desire.

ALCIBIADES

Then there's my glove;
Descend and open your uncharged ports.
Those enemies of Timon's and mine own
Whom you yourselves shall set out for reproof
Fall, and no more. And, to atone your fears
With my more noble meaning, not a man
Shall pass his quarter or offend the stream
Of regular justice in your city's bounds,
But shall be remedied to your public laws
At heaviest answer.

BOTH

'Tis most nobly spoken.

ALCIBIADES

Descend, and keep your words.

[The SENATORS *descend.]*

[Enter a SOLDIER*.]*

SOLDIER

My noble general, Timon is dead,
Entombed upon the very hem o' th' sea,
And on his gravestone this insculpture, which
With wax I brought away, whose soft impression
Interprets for my poor ignorance.

ALCIBIADES

[Reads the Epitaph.] Here lies a wretched corse, of wretched soul bereft.
Seek not my name. A plague consume you, wicked caitiffs left!
Here lie I, Timon, who alive all living men did hate.

Pass by and curse thy fill, but pass and stay not here
thy gait.
These well express in thee thy latter spirits.
Though thou abhorred'st in us our human griefs,
Scorned'st our brains' flow and those our droplets which
From niggard nature fall, yet rich conceit
Taught thee to make vast Neptune weep for aye
On thy low grave, on faults forgiven. Dead
Is noble Timon, of whose memory
Hereafter more. Bring me into your city,
And I will use the olive with my sword,
Make war breed peace, make peace stint war, make each
Prescribe to other, as each other's leech.
Let our drums strike.

[Exeunt.]

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